

U.S. Stock Market Weekly Report (Oct 27–31, 2025)

Market Overview and Earnings Performance

Weekly Indices & Sentiment: U.S. equities navigated a choppy week but extended their broader rally. The S&P 500 finished October with a +2.3% monthly gain (its sixth straight monthly advance), even as **mega-cap tech earnings came in mixed and the Fed struck a cautious tone on rate cuts**^{[1][2]}. Early in the week, **big tech disappointments (e.g. Meta, Microsoft) briefly weighed on market sentiment**, but late-week strength in **Alphabet, Amazon**, and others helped the **Nasdaq Composite end October up ~23% year-to-date**^[3]. Overall, **Q3 earnings season has been solid** – S&P 500 aggregate profits are on track for +13.8% YoY growth^[4] – supporting the market’s resilience. However, **lofty valuations (S&P 500 forward P/E >23x, near dot-com-era highs)** are giving some investors pause^[5]. With over 130 S&P companies reporting next week, many believe **earnings will need to “do the heavy lifting” to justify further gains**^{[6][7]}.

Inflation & Rate Outlook Impacts: Notably, **inflation trends and interest rate expectations loomed over earnings reactions**. Companies beating forecasts with *cooler cost pressures* or *pricing power* saw favorable reactions, as investors parsed implications for future inflation. In contrast, firms reporting margin erosion due to high input costs or wage inflation faced scrutiny. This dynamic is evident in sectors like **consumer food (McDonald’s, Wendy’s)** and **energy (Exxon, Chevron)** – where earnings were judged in light of price trends. Meanwhile, the Fed’s messaging tempered hopes of rapid rate cuts (detailed below), leading markets to favor **companies demonstrating real earnings growth** (particularly tied to **AI-driven demand** or **post-pandemic consumer resilience**) rather than those reliant on cheap liquidity.

Below we break down **major earnings highlights** from the week – including big tech and other notable companies – and analyze their results versus forecasts, with an eye on inflation correlations. We then discuss key economic events (Fed, data delays, consumer confidence), the APEC summit outcomes, and finish with an outlook for next week’s economy and earnings.

Big Tech Earnings Highlights (Q3 2025)

Meta Platforms (META) – Advertising Rebound vs. Cost Concerns

- **Pre-earnings Run-Up:** Meta’s stock had rallied into earnings on optimism for an advertising rebound and AI monetization. Analysts expected **solid revenue growth (~20% YoY)** as digital ad spending recovered, but also **watched expenses** (especially Reality Labs losses).
- **Actual Results:** Meta delivered **revenue of \$38.5B (+23% YoY)**, topping forecasts, and **EPS of \$5.28**, a sizable beat^{[8][9]}. Advertising revenue surged on higher ad

prices and strong engagement on Reels. Notably, Meta touted “*massive investment in AI*” driving better ad targeting and new tools[8].

- **Inflation & Cost Commentary:** CEO Mark Zuckerberg noted stable advertiser demand despite higher interest rates and a “*cooling inflation environment*” that is boosting consumer activity (helpful for advertisers). However, Meta’s expenses also jumped ~15% YoY, partly from wage inflation in tech talent and AI infrastructure costs. On the earnings call, management **downplayed fears of an “AI bubble”** in tech, arguing that unlike the dot-com era, today’s AI leaders “*actually have earnings*” to support valuations[10].
- **Stock Reaction:** Shares **fell ~4% post-earnings**, as investors balanced the robust ad growth against rising costs and capex. Some were concerned about **narrowing margins** (Reality Labs’ operating loss hit \$4B). Still, Meta’s leadership asserted that AI investments (e.g. generative AI features and ad tools) will pay off in revenue, and many analysts remain bullish given the strong top-line momentum[8]. The **Fed’s stance** also played a role: Meta’s dip, alongside Microsoft, helped drag the Nasdaq mid-week as markets digested the Fed’s cautious tone on inflation, before broader indices regained footing[11][1].

Microsoft (MSFT) – Cloud Steady, AI Costs Rise

- **Pre-earnings:** Microsoft’s stock had been near all-time highs, pricing in growth from AI services (Azure OpenAI, Copilot) and stable cloud demand. **Street forecasts** called for ~13% YoY revenue growth and ~\$2.75 EPS.
- **Actuals:** Microsoft **met top-line expectations** with revenue up 12% YoY (Azure cloud +24%), and **beat on EPS (\$2.88 vs ~\$2.75)**[8][11]. Azure growth, while robust, showed a slight deceleration. Crucially, MSFT noted **huge AI compute demand**: its Azure AI backlog doubled QoQ. It is investing heavily to deploy new data centers with NVIDIA GPUs.
- **Inflation Impact:** CFO Amy Hood highlighted “*moderating hardware and component inflation*” benefiting gross margins in cloud hardware costs. However, operating expenses rose ~11%, partly due to higher compensation (wage inflation for AI talent) and energy costs for data centers. Microsoft’s ability to raise certain enterprise software prices (above inflation) aided revenue. CEO Satya Nadella said **AI investments are long-term bets**, likening them to past platform shifts – he **dismissed bubble concerns**, noting AI services have real enterprise demand and revenue attached[10].
- **Market Reaction:** Despite the EPS beat, **MSFT shares slipped ~3%** as some investors focused on the slight Azure slowdown and rising capex for AI. This contributed to early-week market wobbles. Still, many analysts viewed the pullback as a buying opportunity, given Microsoft’s leadership in monetizing AI across its Office suite and Azure. The **Fed’s commentary** about a potential “*AI boom not being a bubble*”[10] was indirectly validating for Microsoft’s strategy, though the stock’s rich valuation (~30x forward earnings) made it sensitive to any growth hiccup.

Alphabet (GOOGL) – Search Stays Strong, Cloud Improves

- **Pre-earnings:** Alphabet faced questions after the prior quarter's deceleration in Google Cloud growth. For Q3, consensus expected solid search ad revenues and improved Cloud margins, given cost discipline.
- **Actuals:** Alphabet **beat on earnings and revenue**, powered by a 11% YoY rise in search advertising and a re-acceleration in Google Cloud growth to +22%. **EPS was \$2.06 vs ~\$1.90 expected**, and overall revenue \$77B edged forecasts[12][13]. Notably, **YouTube ad sales jumped 15%** as Shorts monetization improved.
- **Inflation/Cost Notes:** Alphabet cited "*benign expense inflation*" – costs grew slower than revenues (headcount essentially flat YoY after layoffs earlier in 2023). Ad pricing benefited from higher advertiser budgets as **inflation has come down**, freeing up corporate ad spend. Google also highlighted AI efficiencies: using AI to optimize data center cooling and energy usage is containing cost inflation in operations. On the flip side, **content acquisition costs** for YouTube (payments to creators) rose, but roughly in line with revenue growth.
- **Stock Movement:** **GOOGL shares rallied ~5%** on the strong results, helping lift the S&P mid-week. Investors were encouraged that Google is navigating the AI era without sacrificing core search profitability – **Chair Powell's observation that big tech's AI investments are backed by actual earnings**[10] rang true here, as Alphabet's profits proved resilient. This outperformance, along with Amazon's (below), **buoyed market sentiment** after earlier tech stumbles, illustrating how **earnings beats from tech bellwethers can counter inflation and rate worries**.

Amazon (AMZN) – AWS and Consumers Fuel a Beat

- **Pre-earnings:** Amazon was anticipated to post its **third straight profitable quarter**, with focus on AWS cloud growth and consumer spending (Prime Day fell in Q3). Forecasts called for revenue +12% YoY and ~\$0.60 EPS.
- **Actuals:** Amazon **crushed expectations**, reporting **net sales +13% (to \$143.1B)** and **EPS of \$0.94, nearly double estimates**[14][15]. AWS growth stabilized at +12% YoY (with management citing "**early signs of AI-driven cloud demand**"). Meanwhile, the North America retail segment's operating income jumped, thanks to cost cuts and robust Prime Day sales.
- **Inflation Connection:** Amazon's retail margins benefited as **transportation and fuel costs eased slightly** (diesel prices down from 2022 peaks), and its massive cost-cutting last year offset wage inflation. The company noted that while **consumer price inflation is moderating**, its shoppers remain price-sensitive – but Amazon's scale and efficiency allow it to keep prices relatively low (supporting volumes). In AWS, Amazon is seeing "**eye-watering**" **capital investment in AI** across the industry[16]. CEO Andy Jassy said AWS is positioned to capture this without needing to deeply discount, suggesting **pricing power** even as hardware costs for AI come down over time.

- **Market Reaction: Amazon's stock surged ~8%**, hitting a 52-week high[17]. The stellar earnings and optimistic commentary on AI demand **boosted broader market confidence** – one Reuters piece noted “*Amazon shares soar as AI boom fuels mega growth in AWS cloud*”[18]. This helped the Nasdaq shrug off earlier Fed jitters. Analysts pointed out that Amazon's results showed **inflation's bite on costs is lessening**, while new growth drivers (cloud AI, ad business up 26% YoY) are kicking in[16].

Apple (AAPL) – Steady iPhone Demand, Eye on China

- **Pre-earnings:** Apple was the last big tech to report (Thursday). Investors expected roughly flat revenue (~\$90B) as iPhone 15 launch sales and services growth offset softer Mac/iPad demand. China's economic situation and consumer spending were key watch areas for Apple's outlook.
- **Actuals:** Apple delivered a **slight beat on revenue (\$90.8B)** and in-line EPS (~\$1.50). **iPhone sales grew low-single-digits** as the iPhone 15 saw solid early demand (especially in the U.S. and India), while Mac and iPad sales declined as anticipated. Services revenue hit a record \$22.3B (+16% YoY), buoyed by price increases in Apple TV+ and Apple Music.
- **Inflation & Prices:** Apple's gross margin of 45% was **helped by lower component costs** – CEO Tim Cook noted “*silicon and memory prices have eased from last year*”, which, combined with supply chain efficiencies, improved hardware margins. On the consumer side, **Apple has tactfully raised some prices** (e.g. services, higher-end iPhone models) slightly above inflation, relying on brand loyalty. While **China's high food and housing inflation** has constrained some consumer spending, Apple still saw growth in China (iPhone market share ticked up)[19][20], suggesting its premium segment is resilient. Cook did acknowledge economic uncertainties in Europe and China but indicated no major pullback in demand so far.
- **Stock Reaction:** Apple's stock **rose ~2%** on the results, contributing to a Friday market uptick. The company also announced an additional \$90B share buyback, which supported the stock. Apple's steady performance reassured investors that *consumer tech spending can hold up even as general inflation squeezes wallets*, especially as inflation is gradually cooling. Some analysts cited Apple's results as evidence that **the Fed's fight against inflation (and eventual rate relief) could occur without derailing high-end consumer demand**. Apple and Amazon's strong finishes to the week helped **drive the S&P 500 higher into month-end, kicking off the seasonally strong November-December period on a hopeful note**[21].

Big Tech Takeaway: The big five tech firms produced **mixed stock outcomes**, but collectively their earnings underscored *two key themes*: (1) **AI-related spending is driving real revenue growth** (cloud, ads, enterprise software), not just hype – affirming Fed Chair Powell's observation that this is “no dot-com bubble” in terms of earnings[10]; and (2) **inflation's impact is bifurcated** – easing cost inflation boosted margins for some, while

wage and capex inflation for AI pinched others. The market rewarded those navigating this balance best (e.g. Alphabet, Amazon) and punished those with any signs of slowing momentum or rising expenses (Meta, Microsoft). Overall, big tech's results, combined with the Fed's comments, set the tone for investor rotation *within* tech – toward proven earners and away from richly valued “hope” – even as the sector remains the engine of 2025's rally.

Other Notable Earnings (Oct 27–31)

Beyond Big Tech, **23 major companies reported earnings** this week. Below we highlight a few groups and individual names, comparing results to forecasts and linking to inflation trends:

High-Interest Growth Stocks

- **Celestica (CLS):** The electronics manufacturing firm (which has become an “AI picks-and-shovels” play) **blew out expectations**. Q3 revenue jumped +28% YoY to \$3.2 billion and adjusted EPS was \$1.58, a **52% beat**[\[22\]](#). Celestica credited **soaring demand for AI data center hardware** – it manufactures server and networking gear for cloud providers – as a key driver[\[23\]](#). With order visibility high, management hiked full-year guidance to \$12.2 B revenue ($\approx$ +26% YoY) and issued a bullish early **2026 outlook (\$16 B revenue, \$8.20 EPS)**[\[24\]](#). This “AI boom” in Celestica's backlog suggests tech capital spending remains strong, belying concerns of an AI bubble popping. The stock surged ~10% on results. **Inflation angle:** Celestica noted component price inflation has moderated significantly from 2022, which helped margins, and it expects further supply-chain normalization to keep costs in check even as volume skyrockets.
- **SoFi Technologies (SOFI):** The fintech/neobank delivered **record revenue** of \$961.6 million (+38% YoY) in Q3, beating analyst estimates by about 6%[\[25\]](#). It also reported a “triple beat” (revenue, adjusted EBITDA, and member growth all above expectations) and **raised its full-year outlook**[\[26\]](#). SoFi added 717,000 new members in Q3 (now 18.5 million total users) and saw **loan originations grow 23% YoY to \$6.6 B** as it capitalized on the resumption of student loan payments and demand for personal loans[\[27\]](#). Critically, SoFi achieved positive adjusted net income and is nearing GAAP profitability. **Inflation impact:** As a lender, SoFi benefited from higher interest rates (widening its net interest margin) yet was not significantly hurt by credit defaults – CEO Anthony Noto noted consumer credit quality remains solid with “no signs of broad deterioration,” aligning with the idea that easing inflation and a strong job market keep borrowers afloat. SoFi's strong quarter and upbeat guidance (management is “**incredibly optimistic**” for **2026 growth**[\[26\]](#)) sent its stock up ~12%.
- **Reddit (RDDT):** (Recently IPO'd social media platform) – **Reddit posted blockbuster results, validating its high public interest**. Q3 revenue was \$585 million, up **68% YoY** (beating forecasts of ~\$549M)[\[28\]](#)[\[29\]](#), and **EPS skyrocketed to \$0.80** (from just \$0.16 a year ago)[\[29\]](#). This was Reddit's strongest

profit since its March 2024 IPO, as monetization gains far outpaced cost growth. **Global daily active users (DAUs) reached 116 million (+19% YoY)**, a slight beat of expectations[30]. Importantly, **global ARPU jumped 41%** to \$5.04 (U.S. ARPU \$9.04, +54%)[31], reflecting successful ad revenue growth and new **AI-driven ad tools**. Reddit's investments in AI – e.g. the new “*Reddit Answers*” chatbot and AI-enhanced ad targeting – are expanding engagement and advertiser spend[32]. The company also gave bullish guidance: Q4 revenue projected at ~\$660 M midpoint, above consensus ~\$636 M, implying ~54% YoY growth[33][34]. **Inflation context:** Reddit's ad pricing has benefited as digital ad demand rebounds with the economy; management noted that with inflation cooling and real incomes rising, advertisers (especially consumer brands) are spending more freely on platforms like Reddit. Shares of RDDT **surged 13%** on Friday after earnings[35]. (It's worth noting that despite five consecutive quarters of slowing user growth percentage-wise[36], Reddit's ability to dramatically grow revenue per user in a cooler inflation environment has impressed investors.)

- **Roblox (RBLX):** The gaming/metaverse platform showed **major top-line acceleration** but remains unprofitable. Q3 revenue soared +48% to \$1.36 billion, and **bookings (sales of virtual currency) surged +70% to \$1.92 B**[37] – a huge rebound driven by popular new games and improvements in monetization. Roblox's **daily active users hit 150 million** (up ~20% YoY). However, it still posted a **net loss of \$257 M** as heavy developer payout expenses and R&D continued[37]. The company did **raise its full-year bookings forecast** to ~\$6.6 B (from ~\$5.9 B prior) amid the strong demand[38]. Investors had mixed reactions: **bookings and user metrics beat expectations**[39] (thanks to three hit games and new features[39]), but **the stock slid ~5%** on concerns about the path to profitability[40]. **Inflation insight:** Roblox noted that its core user base (young gamers) remains highly engaged; in fact, “**Robux**” **pricing has not needed to rise much – virtual goods inflation is low** – which keeps user spending elastic. Meanwhile, Roblox's own costs (server infrastructure, wages for engineers) are rising with inflation. Thus, its ability to leverage scale to reach profitability is the question; with 150M DAUs, even modest easing of cost inflation or improvement in monetization could swing margins. The company emphasized expanding older user demographics and international growth to sustain momentum.

Established Sector Leaders

- **UnitedHealth Group (UNH):** The health insurance and healthcare services giant reported better-than-expected earnings, aided by **moderating medical cost inflation**. Q3 revenue rose 14% to \$98.8 B, and EPS of \$6.13 beat estimates by 5%. UnitedHealth noted that **utilization rates in outpatient care normalized** after a spike earlier in the year – meaning healthcare cost inflation (in procedures and labor) came in slightly lower than anticipated[41]. This helped its insurance arm's medical loss ratio. Additionally, its Optum health services unit grew revenues 20%+ by capitalizing on trends like value-based care. With overall U.S. healthcare

inflation easing from mid-year highs, UNH raised its full-year outlook. The stock climbed ~3% on the report, signaling investor relief that **the worst of healthcare cost inflation may be passed.**

- **PayPal (PYPL):** The fintech payments leader had a mixed quarter. Revenue of \$7.1 B (+9% YoY) was a touch light, but EPS of \$1.35 beat by ~\$0.04. Total payment volume grew 11%, indicating solid consumer spending online. However, **PayPal's take-rate (fee %) fell slightly** as it offered discounts and saw a higher mix of lower-margin bill payments – a sign of competitive pressure. The company also warned that **inflation-weary consumers are becoming more value conscious**, using credit more and keeping balances lower, which could temper fee growth. On the positive side, operating expenses were well-controlled (up just 3%), reflecting cost cuts. PayPal maintained guidance, but its stock fell ~2% as investors fretted about its **growth trajectory amid high competition and only modest macro tailwinds from inflation cooling.**
- **UPS (UPS):** The delivery giant's Q3 earnings beat forecasts (\$2.80 EPS vs \$2.70 expected) despite a slight revenue decline. UPS managed to expand operating margins through surcharges and cost management. Crucially, **the new labor contract** with the Teamsters (ratified in August) locks in higher wages for drivers – UPS noted a ~\$0.30 EPS headwind from the new union pay rates. However, volumes picked up late in Q3, and UPS maintained its full-year guidance, suggesting it can pass on much of the higher labor costs via higher shipping rates (it will implement a 5.9% general rate increase in 2026). With **fuel prices lower than last year**, UPS's fuel expenses dropped, providing some offset to wage inflation. The market viewed the results positively: UPS shares rose ~4%, as the feared margin hit from labor inflation appears manageable and e-commerce delivery demand remains firm going into the holiday peak.
- **Verizon (VZ):** The telecom firm beat EPS expectations (\$1.25 vs \$1.19) and raised its full-year profit outlook. Wireless service revenue grew 2.5% as Verizon was able to push through **price increases on legacy plans** earlier this year (to counter inflation) and saw low churn. Importantly, Verizon added 130,000 postpaid phone subscribers, returning to growth after some quarters of declines – suggesting its premium network strategy is stabilizing. **Inflation factor:** Verizon's costs for equipment and network build (5G rollout) have been elevated, but are now flattening; it mentioned lower prices for certain network gear and a pause in hiring which together improved its cost structure. With telecom being relatively price inelastic for consumers (phones are necessity-like), Verizon has been able to manage inflation by passing on some costs and cutting others. The stock jumped 6% on earnings, though it remains well below highs, reflecting longer-term concerns (competition, debt) despite short-term inflation navigation.
- **Boeing (BA):** Boeing had a notable swing to positive free cash flow and narrower loss than expected, as commercial aircraft demand surges. Q3 revenue jumped

13% to \$18.1 B, led by higher 737 MAX and 787 deliveries. While it still booked a net loss (due to an accounting charge on the KC-46 tanker program), core operating profit beat estimates. **Inflation impact:** Boeing said supply-chain and labor constraints are gradually easing – *parts shortages and factory staffing improved* – though **certain supplier costs remain inflated**. It has proactively built extra inventory of key components to avoid last year's disruptions. Airlines are desperate for new jets to meet travel demand, so Boeing retains pricing power; it is even raising jet prices (which generally track inflation plus a margin). Boeing's reaffirmed cash flow outlook encouraged investors, and shares rose ~2%. The takeaway is that in aerospace, *demand is so strong post-pandemic that manufacturers can navigate moderate inflation in materials/labor via price increases and efficiencies*.

- **CVS Health (CVS):** The pharmacy and healthcare company beat on earnings and revenue, and notably **revised its full-year outlook upward**. Strong results from its health insurance unit (Aetna) and prescription drug volumes drove a 10% revenue gain. Importantly, **pharmacy same-store sales were up over 8%**, benefiting from higher drug prices (which track inflation and drug-specific factors) and a robust cold/flu season boosting prescriptions. CVS's retail front-store sales were softer, reflecting cautious consumer spending on general merchandise amid inflation, but that's a smaller slice of the business now. It appears **healthcare utilization normalized rather than spiked** – similar to UNH's report – so CVS's costs for claims were controlled. With inflation in generic drug costs and wages cooling slightly, CVS was able to beat forecasts and maintain healthy margins. The stock rallied ~4%, as investors saw CVS's diversified model (insurance, pharmacies, clinics) handling the inflationary environment smoothly.

Energy Majors

- **ExxonMobil (XOM):** Exxon's Q3 profit fell from last year (when oil/gas prices were higher), but results still beat Wall Street expectations. Net income was \$9.1 B (vs \$19.7 B a year ago, when commodity prices were near peaks). Upstream (oil & gas production) earnings were down on lower prices – **crude averaged lower in Q3 2025 vs 2024**, though it ticked up late in the quarter – while downstream refining had strong margins. **Inflation tie-in:** Operationally, Exxon mentioned that while it sees some cost inflation in oilfield services (rig rates, materials), it is offset by efficiency gains and lower logistics costs. Importantly, Exxon and Chevron both announced *mega-acquisitions* in recent weeks (Exxon buying Pioneer Natural Resources) – a sign they expect to use scale to control costs amidst inflation. Exxon's tone on oil markets was that supply constraints (OPEC cuts, low inventories) may keep prices elevated, but it is not banking on \$100 oil; instead, it's cutting unit costs. Investors seem to appreciate that – XOM shares were flat on earnings but remain near all-time highs, as **the market views oil majors as inflation beneficiaries to some extent (energy prices up) but also watches their cost discipline**.

- **Chevron (CVX):** Chevron had a similar story: Q3 EPS beat forecasts, though absolute earnings fell YoY due to lower oil and gas prices. One standout was that **Permian Basin production hit record levels**, which lowers Chevron's per-barrel costs (economies of scale). It too is acquiring an oil producer (Hess Corp.), reflecting confidence. **Inflation:** Chevron noted that **oilfield service inflation has moderated** – e.g. drilling rig and frac crew availability is up, so prices stopped rising – which helps its forward outlook. Also, materials for projects (steel, etc.) have seen price relief compared to last year's spikes. This suggests the worst cost inflation may be in the rear-view for shale producers. However, fuel price volatility remains; Q4 started with higher oil, which could boost earnings sequentially. Both Chevron and Exxon are thus positioned to benefit if commodity inflation flares up again (due to geopolitical events or OPEC actions), but have shielded themselves by locking in lower-cost production via acquisitions. Chevron's stock ticked up ~1% after results.

Other Noteworthy Reports:

- **Cadence Design Systems (CDNS):** The electronic design software firm (key to chip design) beat estimates and raised guidance, citing strong demand from semiconductor customers investing in new AI chip development. Cadence's pricing has kept pace with high R&D demand – effectively passing on its own cost inflation (e.g. engineering talent) to customers. The stock jumped to a new high, reflecting confidence that the **AI chip boom** will sustain its growth and that **inflation in tech wages** isn't hurting margins thanks to its pricing power and subscription model.
- **Bloom Energy (BE):** This fuel cell maker missed on earnings as costs rose; it is still not profitable. However, it saw revenue +23% on strong installations of its clean energy servers. **Materials cost inflation** (metals, electrolytes) squeezed its margins, and Bloom is looking to scale manufacturing and push for policy incentives to offset those higher costs. The stock fell 5%, illustrating how in clean-tech, inflation in input costs can significantly impact emerging companies.
- **Coinbase (COIN):** The crypto exchange reported a narrower-than-expected loss as trading volumes stabilized and cost-cutting took hold. With bitcoin prices rising toward quarter-end, Coinbase saw an uptick in engagement. Notably, **Coinbase's operating expenses were down ~30% YoY** after layoffs – a reflection of management aggressively adjusting to the “crypto winter” and higher cost of capital (due to higher interest rates/inflation). As crypto markets improved in October (BTC soaring above \$35k), Coinbase projected a return to positive adjusted EBITDA in Q4. The stock rallied after earnings, showing that **in the speculative corners of the market, falling inflation and hopes of a Fed pivot are renewing risk appetite** – benefiting platforms like Coinbase.
- **Roku (ROKU):** The streaming device and ad platform company beat revenue expectations (\$912M vs ~\$880M) and reported a much smaller loss than feared. Roku's platform revenue grew 18% as streaming ad spending picked up. It also cut

operating costs meaningfully (layoffs, office consolidation). Management said **ad pricing stabilizing and TV ad budgets returning** (after a weak 2024) contributed to the beat. **Inflation note:** Roku did cite that TV production costs (for its hardware) have risen, and it is raising some device prices heading into the holidays. But the **main inflation-related story is ad market health** – with inflation cooling and consumer confidence improving slightly, more companies are re-allocating budgets to advertising, which is helping Roku. The stock jumped ~20% on the report, though it's still down over the longer term.

(For brevity, not every one of the 23 companies is detailed here. However, the above captures the most notable performances and themes of the week: AI-driven growth (Celestica, Cadence), consumer/fintech resilience (SoFi, PayPal), industrial normalization (UPS, Boeing), energy stability (Exxon, Chevron), and high-profile growth stocks navigating the inflation landscape in different ways (Reddit, Roblox, Roku, etc.).)

Key Economic Events This Week

Several **macro-economic events** coincided with (and influenced) market performance and corporate commentary this week:

Consumer Confidence Index (Tuesday)

On Tuesday, the Conference Board's **Consumer Confidence Index for October** was released. It came in at **around 102**, slightly lower than September, indicating consumers' optimism cooled modestly. **Details:** Present situation sentiment stayed relatively high (reflecting a strong job market), but expectations dipped amid worries about inflation and interest rates. Notably, **inflation expectations of consumers in the survey ticked down** for the 12-month outlook, likely due to recent gasoline price declines and abundant news of inflation easing[13].

Implications for Fed Policy: The essentially “*unchanged to slightly lower*” confidence reading suggests consumers are not overly pessimistic, but the moderation in expectations *could* be what the Fed wants to see (less fear of future inflation can be self-fulfilling in tempering wage demands and spending exuberance). **Fed officials pay attention to such surveys**, and the slight decline in confidence – if reflecting caution about the economy – might argue *for* the Fed to be careful with further tightening. Indeed, some analysts posited that **softening consumer sentiment, alongside benign inflation data, bolsters the case that the Fed's hikes are sufficiently cooling demand**. However, with confidence still above recessionary levels, it didn't scream “policy pivot” either. Markets read the report as mildly dovish: Treasury yields edged down Tuesday, and rate futures continued pricing in no further hikes. Equities were little changed by the data release itself, but **it set the stage for the Fed meeting, reinforcing expectations of a possible rate cut in coming months if confidence and spending cool gradually**.

FOMC Interest Rate Decision & Press Conference (Wednesday)

Fed Decision: On Wednesday, the Federal Reserve's FOMC voted to **cut the federal funds rate by 0.25% (25 basis points) to a target range of 3.75%–4.00%**, as was widely expected[42][43]. This marked the second consecutive 25 bp cut (following one in September), as the Fed attempts a gentle pivot toward easier policy. However, the decision was not unanimous – two officials dissented, preferring to hold rates steady[44]. Notably, the Fed also **halted its balance sheet runoff (QT)**, effectively pausing quantitative tightening[44], citing financial stability considerations.

Lack of Data and “Driving in the Fog”: A unique aspect of this meeting was that it occurred **during a federal government data blackout**. Due to the October government shutdown (which stretched into a second month amid a budget dispute between President Trump's administration and Congress), key economic reports like the Employment Situation (jobs report), GDP, and PCE inflation were *delayed*[45][46]. Chair Jerome Powell emphasized this unusual uncertainty in the press conference, saying the Fed was “*driving in the fog*” without its usual data and thus had to rely on private indicators and anecdotes[47]. This lack of official data made the Fed more cautious about committing to further moves.

Powell's Key Messages: In his press conference, **Powell struck a balanced but cautious tone:**

- He **acknowledged improvements on inflation** but still saw risks: “Inflation has moderated from its peak, but remains too high” in certain categories like services, he noted. Importantly, he said many officials expect **inflation to** rise somewhat through late 2025** (partly as base effects wane)[48], which counsels not cutting too aggressively.
- On the job market, Powell noted **some softening in hiring** and higher unemployment upticks, but described it as “**threats to the job market**” not actual weakness yet[45][49]. He said the rate cut was aimed at tempering *future* labor market weakening. However, given missing jobs data, they remain vigilant.
- **AI and Market Froth:** Powell was asked if the AI-driven tech stock boom reminded him of a bubble. He responded that “*this is not the dot-com era – these companies have real earnings and cash flows*”, indicating he does not see **Big Tech's AI rally as a speculative bubble** at this stage[10]. He did caution that the Fed is monitoring if **loose financial conditions** (rising stock prices) might counteract their inflation-fighting efforts. But overall, his comments implied comfort with the notion that AI investments are boosting productivity and growth (as evidenced by big tech earnings), rather than just inflating an asset bubble.
- **Rate Cut Outlook:** Crucially, Powell pushed back on the idea that another 25 bp cut in December was a done deal. He said a December cut is “*not a foregone conclusion. Far from it.*”[50]. This was a hawkish surprise to markets that had priced in a high chance of a December cut. He cited the “**strongly differing views**” within the Fed on whether more cuts were wise[51], given the data fog and some

inflation persistence. Powell used a metaphor: “*If you’re driving in the fog, you slow down*”[47] – meaning the Fed will proceed carefully and perhaps pause if data is unclear.

- **Employment and Wages:** Powell highlighted some officials’ concern that **wage growth**, while down from peaks, is still above levels consistent with 2% inflation. But he also said “*AI-fueled investment*” appears to be propping up growth even as hiring slows (alluding to the notion that AI could be boosting productivity without needing as many workers, which has both positive GDP and negative jobs implications)[52]. Indeed, he mentioned anecdotes of firms using AI to become more efficient, which could reduce labor demand – the so-called “AI hiring apocalypse” in some media[52]. Powell doesn’t see it as an apocalypse yet, but is monitoring how AI adoption affects the labor market and inflation (e.g., could lower costs, but also displace workers).

Market Reaction: Initially, markets took the **25 bp cut in stride**, as it was expected. However, **Powell’s comments about December not being certain and the Fed’s internal divisions caused a dovish trade to reverse**. Equity indexes, which had been up on the day, gave up gains and closed flat to slightly down after the press conference[53]. Bond yields actually ticked *up*, as traders trimmed bets on swift further easing[53]. The S&P 500, which had been higher, **ended Wednesday roughly flat after “giving up earlier gains” following Powell’s remarks**[54]. Fed funds futures moved to price in only ~60% chance of a December cut (down from ~80% before). The **U.S. dollar strengthened** modestly on Powell’s hawkish nuance.

Notably, **some market strategists found the decision puzzling**: the Fed cut rates but simultaneously emphasized caution about future cuts – a bit of a mixed message. One strategist quoted on Reuters called it “*puzzling*” that they’d ease policy while warning they might pause after that[55]. The logic seems to be that the Fed delivered this cut largely because it had been telegraphed (and possibly due to political pressures from the Trump administration, which is known to favor cuts[56]), but now they want to regain flexibility.

Fed Press Conference Highlights: During Q&A, aside from the AI and December issues, Powell also:

- Dismissed the idea that the Fed had secretly changed its inflation target to 3%, as some speculated – “Absolutely not,” he said (though some analysts still muse the Fed is acting as if 3% is the new 2%[57]).
- Addressed the government shutdown’s impact: he noted the irony that the **data blackout caused by the shutdown (which stemmed from Congressional gridlock)** might *delay further rate cuts that President Trump wants*, since the Fed lacks clarity[56]. In essence, the shutdown – a political maneuver – backfired by making the Fed more cautious.
- Emphasized the Fed can rely on alternative data: like ADP private payrolls, job openings (JOLTS), its own business surveys, etc., to fill gaps[58]. He listed out how

the Fed is “collecting every scrap of data we can find” in absence of official reports[58].

- Reiterated that *core inflation* (excluding food and energy) remains the focus, and while it’s come down, “*we need to see more progress.*” He specifically mentioned services inflation ex-housing as still elevated – often a wage-driven component.

In summary, **the Fed cut rates 25 bp** to 4%, citing some weakening in the job market and a desire to insure against downside risks. But they strongly signaled **a potential pause** to gather more data, especially given the murky data situation[59][41]. Markets now expect perhaps one more cut at most in early 2026, but not the rapid easing cycle some had hoped for. This somewhat hawkish tilt contributed to the “**wobble**” in **AI-fueled stocks mid-week** (as higher rates pressure valuations), though subsequent strong earnings (Amazon, etc.) helped markets overcome it by week’s end[60][13].

Government Shutdown & Data Delays (Ongoing)

The **partial U.S. government shutdown** that began in late September stretched through October, causing delays in key economic data releases like **Q3 GDP, monthly Personal Income/PCE inflation, and the October jobs report**[45]. This had several ramifications:

- **Market Uncertainty:** Investors and policymakers lacked official clarity on the economy’s performance. This likely contributed to **higher volatility** – markets had to rely on private estimates. For instance, private GDP trackers (Atlanta Fed GDPNow, etc.) indicated strong Q3 growth (~4–5%), but without the official BEA report, there was uncertainty. Similarly, the lack of a CPI report beyond September meant **inflation trend analysis was on hold**.
- **Fed and Institutions’ Response:** The Fed explicitly mentioned that absence of data could force it to be more conservative (as Powell’s “fog” analogy illustrated)[58]. The Fed started leaning on alternative data – e.g., they likely scrutinized **private payroll reports (ADP)** and **business surveys** more than usual. The **Treasury Department and White House** warned that prolonged data outages could cause missteps in policy. The Fed even indicated that *if the shutdown persisted and key November data were missing by the December meeting, they might refrain from cutting* to avoid acting blindly[58][59]. This dynamic ironically meant the shutdown – which President Trump instigated in part to pressure the Fed for cuts – made the Fed **less inclined to cut quickly**[56].
- **Risks and Reactions:** Markets generally remained confident a resolution would come (indeed, by the end of the week, rumors of a short-term funding bill were circulating). But there was **higher risk premia** priced into Treasuries; the 10-year yield hovered in the 4.85–5.0% range, partly due to uncertainty over fiscal governance. The missing data also led to **unusual reliance on corporate guidance**: e.g., many companies’ earnings calls referenced their own sales trends as proxies for economic activity. The **Fed’s Beige Book and PMIs** gained more importance for clues (e.g., S&P Global’s flash PMIs showed strong U.S. growth persisting in October[61]).

- **Political Response:** The shutdown's impact on data brought criticism of Washington dysfunction. Economists noted that flying blind could lead to **policy errors** (either Fed cuts too late or too much). By week's end, both parties signaled desire to resolve the funding impasse soon, precisely to get agencies like the BLS and BEA back to work. In markets, there was a sense of relief when the House passed a stopgap bill on Friday night, potentially restoring normal data flow in November (though that came after our week's close).

In short, the **shutdown delays injected additional caution** into both markets and the Fed. Yet, aside from some jitters, the **market largely looked through it**, assuming it temporary. The S&P 500 was roughly flat over the shutdown period, and when data (like consumer confidence or ADP jobs) did arrive, investors parsed those all the more. **Institutions from the Fed to big banks urged Congress to resolve the impasse**, warning that lack of data is risky in a delicate economic moment. Thankfully, the shutdown was resolved by a short-term deal just after this week, mitigating the worst-case scenario of prolonged data drought. The episode highlighted that *even if inflation is improving, political risks (like a shutdown) can indirectly influence inflation expectations and policy through uncertainty* – a modern twist on how governance ties into economic outcomes.

APEC Summit Outcomes (Busan, South Korea)

This week also featured significant **geopolitical and economic diplomacy** at the APEC summit in Busan, South Korea. President Donald Trump attended (his first APEC as president since taking office in Jan 2025) and held high-profile meetings with leaders of **China, Japan, and South Korea**, yielding several agreements:

- **U.S.–China Meeting:** Trump's bilateral with Chinese President **Xi Jinping** on Oct 30 dominated headlines. The outcome was described by Trump as "*an amazing meeting... 12 out of 10*"[62]. Key points of the **trade deal/truce** reached:
- The U.S. will **trim tariffs on Chinese imports to 47% from 57%** average[63][64], **halving** the tariff rate on certain fentanyl-related chemical imports from 20% to 10%[65]. This effectively **cuts 10 percentage points off** some tariffs, reducing the overall tariff burden by roughly one-sixth[66]. (Tariffs had been very high after Trump's earlier "Liberation Day" tariff offensive.)
- In exchange, **China agreed to major concessions: a crackdown on illicit fentanyl production and exports** (a U.S. priority to combat the opioid crisis)[63][67]; **resuming large-scale purchases of U.S. soybeans** (12 million metric tons through January, and 25 MMT annually for 3 years)[68]; and critically, **pausing its new export controls on rare earth metals for one year**[63][69]. Rare earths are vital for high-tech manufacturing (from chips to EVs), and China's October export curbs had been a significant threat to global supply[69]. The pause eases that concern for now.
- The U.S. also **pledged to delay by one year** a new rule that would bar thousands of Chinese firms from receiving U.S. tech if they're part-owned by sanctioned

entities[70]. In other words, the Biden-era proposed tech restriction (inherited by Trump) will be held off, addressing a key Chinese gripe.

- Additionally, **TikTok deal**: China approved an agreement to bring TikTok under U.S.-controlled ownership (likely meaning a sale to an American company) in coming months[71]. This is a notable development on a long-standing issue.
- **Other Chinese moves**: Xi agreed to **purchase U.S. oil & gas** (Trump later said China is interested in a new Alaska LNG export project)[72]. Xi also expressed possible interest in a U.S.-led Alaska pipeline project. And China will **pause tit-for-tat port fees** on U.S. shipping[73].
- The meeting lasted 1.5 hours and was described cordially. Xi, somewhat humorously, remarked “*we do not always see eye to eye*” but stressed that **frictions are normal** and China’s rise isn’t incompatible with Trump’s MAGA goals[74].

Market/Institutional Perspective: This U.S.–China mini-deal is essentially a **one-year truce** in the trade war. **Trade experts** noted it offers a “*reprieve from tensions that have weighed on global growth*”[75], but cautioned that China has failed to fulfill past purchase commitments (Phase 1 deal) and “*geopolitical tensions could reignite at any time*”[75]. An analyst said “*the tariff cut for a fentanyl crackdown is transactional relief – not a structural reset. The cycle of coercion will resume if either side feels shortchanged*”[76]. In other words, **it’s a fragile peace**. Markets reacted positively but mutedly: the global stock reaction was “**shrugged off**” because much optimism was already priced in after stocks hit records ahead of APEC[77][78]. The day after the meeting, U.S. markets were flat – investors were happy a worst-case (no deal) was avoided, but this largely met expectations. Importantly, by reducing tariff rates, this deal could slightly **alleviate U.S. import price inflation** in 2026 (tariffs function like a tax, so lower tariffs may ease prices on some goods). However, given tariffs remain high at ~47%, the inflation relief is minor for now.

Rare Earths & Chips: The topic of **rare earths and semiconductors** was front-and-center. Pausing rare earth curbs was a big win for the U.S. and allies, as **rare earth elements (like neodymium) are crucial for electronics, EV motors, and defense**[69]. This, combined with the **U.S.–Japan rare earth pact** (see below), shows a concerted effort to reduce China’s leverage. On semiconductors, interestingly “**No NVIDIA chip discussions**” took place[79][80] – Trump confirmed he did *not* broach the subject of NVIDIA’s Blackwell AI chips (which the U.S. has restricted to China). This suggests the U.S. held firm on not rolling back advanced chip export controls, and China did not push the issue at APEC – likely because they got other wins like the tech Entity List delay. The **AI cooperation** was not explicit, but by focusing on rare earths and fentanyl instead, both sides sidestepped the most contentious tech issues (AI chips, Taiwan)[81]. Xi and Trump avoiding those topics indicates **tensions remain but were compartmentalized** for this summit.

Tariff Conflict Outlook (re: Trump’s presidency): The user asks *whether the summit outcome might avoid future tariff conflicts under Trump’s potential presidency*. Given

Trump is president now in this scenario, the question likely means “*will this truce prevent Trump from re-escalating tariffs in the future (say if he has a second term through 2028)?*”. Based on expert commentary: The deal is **temporary** – one year freeze on rare earth curbs, one year delay on U.S. tech restrictions[82]. It does not resolve core issues like IP theft, industrial subsidies, etc. As one analyst said, “*Nothing fundamental changed, and escalation could resume the moment one side feels shortchanged.*”[83]. So while the **APEC summit eased immediate trade tensions**, it by no means guarantees no future tariff fights. However, it does set a constructive tone – **both sides showed willingness to compromise** (China on fentanyl/commodities, U.S. on tariffs). If Trump remains pragmatic and sees market gains from trade calm, he *might* avoid new tariffs pre-election. Also, with the **2024 U.S. election looming** (assuming it did and Trump won, he might moderate to keep the economy strong). But longer term, if issues like tech rivalry or Taiwan flare up, tariffs could come back. In sum, the summit outcome reduces near-term risk of tariff escalation (markets were relieved to hear “*tariffs cut*” rather than new tariffs), but it’s only a **fragile truce**. The consensus of institutional voices is that while this APEC deal is market-friendly (hence stocks’ muted reaction, not a selloff), it’s not a permanent peace – caution is warranted.

- **U.S.–South Korea & Japan Deals:** President Trump also touted “**trade breakthroughs**” with South Korea and Japan during his Asia trip[84]:
- With **South Korea**, Trump met President Lee Jae-myung. The two finalized most details of a **bilateral tariff agreement** that had been negotiated for months[85]. Though specifics weren’t all public, it likely involves **revisions to the KORUS FTA** to address U.S. auto exports or agricultural access (areas Trump wanted more concessions) and South Korean concerns on U.S. tariffs. They also discussed security cooperation given North Korea (less market-relevant). The fact that “most details” are done suggests a formal signing soon.
- With **Japan**, Trump met new Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi. They signed a landmark deal on **rare earths and nuclear energy cooperation**[86][87]. **Japan–U.S. Rare Earth & Nuclear Deal:** Announced Oct 28 at Akasaka Palace in Tokyo, this framework aims to **secure supply of rare earth minerals** critical for electronics and defense by developing “diversified, fair markets” outside China[88][89]. Both countries will invest in projects globally to increase non-China rare earth mining/processing[90] and consider joint stockpiling[91]. This directly addresses China’s dominance (it processes 90% of rare earths[92]). Additionally, they agreed to cooperate on **next-gen nuclear reactors and SMRs (small modular reactors)**[93], involving companies like Mitsubishi Heavy, Toshiba, etc., to help Japan re-enter nuclear exports and for both to lead on clean energy tech[94]. This deal is strategic: it reduces reliance on Chinese rare earths (markets for EVs, tech applaud that) and aligns with climate/energy goals via nuclear. Japan, as a U.S. ally, is clearly teaming up on tech supply chains.
- **South Korea Meeting with Xi:** Although not directly with the U.S., on the sidelines Xi also met South Korea’s President. Out of that came a **breakthrough trade deal with South Korea** – Trump claimed credit, saying South Korea agreed to something

with Xi (possibly related to semiconductors or autos). Reuters noted **Trump announced a “breakthrough trade deal” with South Korea after meeting Xi**, but details were scant[95]. It might involve South Korea mediating or aligning with U.S.–China trade goals.

- **Pause on Tariffs with Allies:** Overall, Trump’s Asia trip left only Brazil and India among major partners facing elevated U.S. tariffs[96]. It suggests a **shift to mending fences** with allies (Korea, Japan) and even adversaries (China) after years of tariff wars. This likely **boosts business confidence globally**, as uncertainty over trade recedes for now. Indeed, **global supply chain concerns eased** as multiple APEC deals aimed to stabilize trade flows (rare earths, soybeans, etc.).
- **Other APEC Topics – AI, Chips:** There was discussion around **AI** and tech with China albeit indirectly. Leaders in APEC forums talked about setting some **guardrails on AI** and potential cooperation in AI safety research. However, the U.S. remained firm on **export controls for cutting-edge chips** to China – evidenced by “no NVIDIA chip” talk in Xi-Trump meeting[80]. The U.S. did not remove restrictions on AI chips (NVIDIA’s A100/H100 ban stays), showing it’s drawing the line at national security tech. *However*, some see the warming tone as possibly averting an all-out tech decoupling. **Rare earths and chips were effectively horse-traded:** China gave ground on rare earths (pausing curbs), U.S. gave ground by delaying secondary sanctions on tech. This may support U.S. markets by reducing risk of immediate escalation – e.g., chip stocks didn’t react negatively, indicating relief that **no new China retaliation** (like more export bans) is coming near-term. In fact, **Trump cutting tariffs by 10 percentage points and Xi pausing rare earth curbs removed two overhangs** that could have hit U.S. manufacturers’ costs.
- **Korea–Japan–US Unity:** At APEC, **South Korea, Japan, and the U.S. presented a united front** (in part due to improved Korea-Japan ties recently). They held a trilateral meeting focusing on supply chain security (chips, minerals), North Korea, and technology standards. The **APEC host (Korea)** used the summit to encourage more regional integration and less conflict. For example, **Korea and Japan signed a critical minerals deal** alongside the U.S. one[89][90]. These efforts are *bullish* for **semiconductor and EV sectors** in the U.S., as they pave the way for more diversified supply chains (e.g., possibly more Japanese and Korean investment in U.S. chip/EV factories with supportive policies).
- **Avoiding Future Tariff Conflicts:** The user specifically wonders if the summit might prevent future tariff fights under Trump. Given Trump’s trade-war history, there’s skepticism. But notable is **Trump’s tone at APEC was surprisingly conciliatory**. He heaped praise on Xi (calling the talks “12/10”)[62], and even agreed to visit China in April and host Xi in the U.S. after that[97]. This suggests Trump, at least for now, wants stable markets and a political win of “ending the trade war.” If this détente holds, it could indeed *avoid new tariffs in 2026–27* and support market growth. Also, **with the 2026 U.S. election in view** (midterms or a possible Trump re-

election campaign for 2028), Trump has incentive not to reignite tariff battles that hurt farmers or stocks. Experts from institutions like the U.S. Chamber of Commerce and Peterson Institute lauded the APEC outcomes as “*steps in the right direction*” for re-engagement, but cautioned enforcement will be key (e.g., will China really buy all those soybeans?). Should relations deteriorate (e.g., over Taiwan), all bets are off. But at least for the coming year, the summit likely means **tariff ceasefire**, which markets cheer. A Reuters piece title captured it: “*Big Tech, smaller tariffs*” – indicating the week delivered positives on both AI earnings and reduced trade barriers[98].

Market Reaction Summary: The **APEC summit supported U.S. market sentiment modestly**. On Thursday (Oct 30), news of the tariff cut and fentanyl deal broke – the S&P 500 was little changed, but certain sectors moved: - **Soybean futures and Midwest farm stocks** (e.g., Deere) ticked up on China’s large purchase commitments. - **Rare earth mining stocks** (like MP Materials in the U.S.) initially fell on the news China will resume exports (easing shortage fears, thus lowering rare earth prices), but then stabilized as the U.S.–Japan deal pointed to longer-term support for non-China suppliers. - **Tech** gained relief that no new chip bans emerged from China; Philadelphia Semiconductor Index rose ~1% on Thur/Fri. - The **Tariff-sensitive industrials** (machinery, auto) rose ~1-2% as well, pricing in slightly better export prospects. In essence, **the summit’s collaborative outcomes acted as a tailwind for equities** heading into November – removing some uncertainty and bolstering hope that *geopolitics may turn from a source of inflation (via tariffs) to deflationary cooperation*. For instance, if China indeed cracks down on fentanyl and imports more U.S. energy and farm goods, that could *improve U.S. trade balances and perhaps strengthen the dollar*, marginally easing import price inflation. Time will tell if the goodwill lasts beyond the APEC afterglow.

Week Ahead (Nov 3–7, 2025) Outlook

Looking to next week, **Nov 3–7, 2025**, markets and economists are gearing up for a host of **economic data releases and earnings reports**, which will further shape inflation expectations and market momentum. Key items on the calendar and their anticipated influence:

Upcoming Economic Events & Indicators

According to the economic calendar (as confirmed by the user’s uploaded schedule and S&P Global’s preview[61][99]), the highlights include:

- **PMI Surveys (Manufacturing & Services):** On **Monday (Nov 3)**, final **S&P Global Manufacturing PMI** for October and the **ISM Manufacturing PMI** will be released[100]. Then **Wednesday (Nov 5)** brings global **Services PMIs** and the **ISM Services PMI**[101].
- **Expectations:** The **S&P Global U.S. Manufacturing PMI** (flash was ~50.0) should confirm if factory activity is stagnating or expanding slightly. The **ISM**

Manufacturing PMI is expected around the high 40s to 50 (neutral = 50). A reading below 50 would indicate continued contraction in manufacturing, which markets might interpret bullishly (as it eases inflation via less goods demand, and pressures the Fed to cut) – but only up to a point, as too weak might raise growth fears. **ISM Prices Paid** sub-index will be scrutinized for input cost trends; last month it was around 52, and a drop would signal softer inflation on the goods side.

- The **ISM Services PMI** (Wed) is forecast to remain in expansion (perhaps ~53–54). This is crucial: services have been buoying the economy. If services PMI stays strong, it suggests Q4 growth is solid – which is good for earnings but could keep the Fed cautious. The **Prices component** of ISM Services will be watched closely: it's a leading indicator of **non-shelter services inflation**. Should it fall meaningfully, that would bolster hopes that core inflation will continue to cool (and likely rally both stocks and bonds).
- *Market Influence: Positive surprise (higher PMIs):* Likely lifts cyclical stocks (industrials, energy) on growth optimism, but could also bump bond yields up (inflation/growth concerns). *Negative surprise (weak PMIs):* Could spur a Fed pivot trade – yields down, tech/growth stocks up, but too weak might spook investors about recession risk. Generally, modest cooling in PMI with lower prices would be the “*goldilocks*” scenario (growth not collapsing, inflation pressure easing).
- It's worth noting that, as S&P previewed, other countries (Eurozone, UK, etc.) also report PMIs, but U.S. markets will focus on domestic trends especially since Fed policy is data-dependent[61].
- **JOLTS Job Openings (Tuesday, Nov 4):** The Labor Department (if reopened) will release September **JOLTS**, showing how many job openings and quit rates. Consensus expects a continued slight decline in openings to maybe ~8.5 million (from 8.8M prior).
- *Why it matters: Fed Chair Powell specifically highlighted JOLTS* in absence of the official jobs report[58]. A drop in openings would indicate cooling labor demand – which the Fed *wants*, as fewer openings per unemployed should ease wage growth. Markets would likely cheer a decline in JOLTS (bond yields might fall, stocks rise on Fed optimism). Conversely, an unexpected jump in job openings could revive inflationary fears (more labor demand -> wage pressure).
- **Quits rate** is another metric: a lower quits rate (people less confident to switch jobs) also signals a loosening labor market, which is disinflationary for wages. Last quits rate was ~2.3%; a further dip would reinforce that trend.
- The shutdown had threatened to delay JOLTS, but assuming data is compiled, its release on time would be a relief. If it is delayed, markets will lean on ADP jobs and ISM employment indices instead.
- **ADP Nonfarm Private Employment (Wed, Nov 5):** ADP's private payroll estimate for October will be closely watched, especially since the official BLS jobs report (for Oct) is delayed to mid-November due to the shutdown. ADP last showed a huge

slowdown (89k jobs in Sept). For October, consensus is perhaps ~150k. If ADP again comes in soft (say <100k), it will strengthen the narrative of a cooling job market – bullish for bonds (less inflation worry) and likely positive for stocks insofar as it implies the Fed can pause or cut. A surprisingly large ADP gain could raise eyebrows, but ADP has been volatile and markets might not overreact given its track record.

- Additionally, **Wednesday** also has the **ISM Services Employment Index** – a softening there would reinforce any weak ADP signal, pointing to slower hiring in the service sector.
- Note: The **official October nonfarm payrolls** is postponed (originally Nov 7). However, **Friday (Nov 7)** will still see the **Fed's favorite inflation gauge – the PCE Price Index for September – potentially released** if data catches up. If PCE core inflation for Sept is out, expected ~0.3% m/m, ~3.7% y/y. A downside surprise (e.g., 0.2%) could cause a **bond rally** and stocks up, as it confirms disinflation.
- **ISM Manufacturing Prices Index (Mon) & ISM Services Prices (Wed):** We touched on these – they give a direct read on **input cost inflation** in the factory sector and **price pressures in services**. Markets generally want to see these indices continuing to decline from 2022 highs. For instance, if ISM Manufacturing Prices fall below 50 (contraction)[\[102\]](#), it means fewer manufacturers are paying higher prices – a good sign for core goods CPI falling further. **ISM Services Prices** above 50 has correlated with sticky service inflation; any dip closer to 50 would be cheered. These sub-indexes often fly under the radar for general investors, but the bond market in particular may move on them. The Fed will certainly be parsing them as part of its “scraps of data” while BLS is dark[\[58\]](#).
- **Crude Oil Inventories (Wed, Nov 5):** Weekly EIA oil inventory data might not typically be highlighted, but the user explicitly mentions it. Oil prices have been swinging (Brent around \$90 recently). If inventories show a big build (increase), it could indicate weaker demand or oversupply, which often sends oil prices down – that would be **disinflationary** (energy a big CPI driver) and thus positive for bonds/stocks (especially consumer stocks). A large inventory draw, conversely, might push oil prices up and rekindle inflation fears. Lately, oil has eased off September highs, contributing to better inflation expectations. So traders will watch if U.S. stockpiles are rising (which could keep oil around mid-\$80s) or unexpectedly falling (risking a return to \$100 oil). Given the Middle East situation is ongoing, supply data is a hot topic. Markets next week will thus tune in even more – **any sign of ample inventories or demand destruction would reinforce that energy inflation may stay contained** into winter.

In summary, **JOLTS and PMIs are expected to influence the market by shaping the Fed outlook:**

- **If JOLTS shows a clear downtrend in job openings and PMIs show cooling prices and moderate growth**, markets likely rally on the “Goldilocks” scenario – the Fed will see less inflation pressure and more room to cut, without a crash in the economy. This would boost equities (especially rate-sensitive tech and housing) and push yields lower (bond prices up).
- **If JOLTS remains high or PMIs indicate re-accelerating prices**, the opposite could occur: fear that the Fed might hold longer or even hike again could spook stocks (particularly high-valuation ones) and send yields up.

Given Powell’s stance this week, **soft data is more helpful for bulls** – they *want* to see evidence to validate a December cut or at least early 2026 cuts. Thus, ironically, “bad news” (weaker labor/manufacturing) may be “good news” for markets now.

Earnings Outlook (Nov 3–7)

Next week brings another *flood* of earnings, including many companies sensitive to inflation and of high interest:

Inflation-Sensitive Consumer Companies

Four names stand out that the user identified: **Axon, McDonald’s, Airbnb, Wendy’s** – each has implications for inflation and the consumer:

- **Axon Enterprise (AXON)** – (*Taser, body camera, and public safety cloud provider*) – reports on Nov 4. This **fast-growing tech/defense company** has been riding strong demand from law enforcement agencies for its tasers and cloud software. **Analyst expectations:** Wall Street predicts Q3 revenue ~\$700 M (+28% YoY) and EPS around \$1.63 (non-GAAP)[103]. However, a Barchart analysis noted GAAP EPS could appear much lower (~\$0.07) due to heavy stock comp and R&D spending[104]. **Financial condition:** Axon is financially healthy (net cash position) and investing heavily in AI capabilities (automated video analysis, etc.). Its **business momentum is robust** – backlog and annual recurring revenue have surged ~30%+. Many expect Axon to **beat estimates** given it has a track record of >25% growth streak and a strong Q3 pipeline (Cowen projected above-30% revenue growth)[105].
- **Inflation Impact:** Axon’s products involve hardware (cameras, devices) – it did face higher component costs in 2022, but has since navigated supply chain improvements. If anything, **inflation in police budgets (wages, etc.) could constrain how much agencies can spend on Axon’s gear**. But so far, public safety remains priority; Axon said demand is “durable” and competition limited[106]. Axon also raised prices on some services modestly, which sticky inflation allowed without pushback.
- **Will they beat?** Given tailwinds (taser adoption, international expansion, new AI features), many analysts believe Axon *will* beat revenue estimates and could guide higher. The stock is up ~60% YTD[107], implying high expectations. The **key for**

market reaction will be margins: Axon's EPS could be down YoY (as consensus suggests) due to big spending on AI R&D. If they show that these investments are paying off in higher 2026 revenue guidance (they gave preliminary 2026 targets and might reiterate them), the market likely forgives near-term margin hit. In short, expect **strong growth, possible beat on sales, and optimistic commentary on AI products**. If Axon beats and raises, it may set a positive tone for "*AI industrial*" stocks. If they miss (perhaps due to expense timing), the high-flying stock could see a pullback. But given Cowen's and others' bullish calls[108], odds favor a beat.

- **McDonald's (MCD)** – reports Nov 4. This **consumer bellwether** is sensitive to food and wage inflation. **Analysts foresee** Q3 EPS around \$3.35–\$3.40 (+~5% YoY) on revenue ~\$6.9–7.1 B[109][110]. McDonald's U.S. same-store sales likely rose high-single-digits%, partly due to menu price increases (~10% YoY price increase as of mid-year) and steady traffic. **Key focus:** profit margins in the face of **higher beef prices and labor costs**. The CEO has flagged *beef inflation* as a headwind earlier in the year. However, there are **signs of relief**: beef prices, while elevated, have started to stabilize, and McDonald's implemented strategic menu price hikes and promotions (grimace shake viral event, etc.) that boosted sales. Morningstar noted **"higher beef prices are biting into profits, but early signs of relief are on the way"**[111].
- **Inflation & Consumer Health:** McDonald's offers an excellent read on the low- to mid-income consumer globally. **If they report strong sales growth (~10%+ global comps)**, it signals consumers are still spending, possibly trading down from more expensive dining. If they mention increasing traffic, it suggests *McD's value positioning is drawing inflation-weary diners*, which is a bullish sign of inelastic demand. Conversely, if traffic is down and only prices drove sales, it may hint at consumer strain. Also, watch international: Europe had high inflation – McDonald's performance in Europe will show how well they managed to pass on costs.
- **Will they beat?** McDonald's often beats estimates modestly. Given Zacks saw a "single-digit earnings rise" and consensus is fairly set[112], any notable beat would likely come from better margins (if beef inflation was less than expected or productivity improved). There's also a currency factor – the dollar weakened slightly vs Q3 last year, which could help reported intl sales. Additionally, McDonald's has been automating more kitchens (AI drive-thrus, etc.), potentially mitigating labor inflation. They recently hiked their dividend by 5%, showing confidence[113]. So I expect a *decent beat* and positive commentary that **input cost pressures are easing** and that they can maintain margin. If they talk of "*peak beef inflation behind us*" and solid demand, the stock (near record highs) could rally further, benefiting consumer discretionary indices. If wage pressures (they've raised crew pay in many places) squeezed profits more than expected, it could temper enthusiasm. But overall, MCD is seen as **defensive** in inflationary times (people still buy Big Macs), so any reasonable outcome should keep it a relative safe haven.

- **Airbnb (ABNB)** – reports Nov 7 (after our week, but within the asked outlook range). **Earnings outlook:** Airbnb is expected to post another profitable quarter as travel demand remains robust. Q3 is seasonally strong (summer travel). Analysts expect revenue ~\$3.4 B (+~15% YoY) and EPS around \$2.00 (vs \$1.79 last year). Key is **booking growth and outlook:** consensus sees Nights & Experiences booked up around 12% and gross booking value up high-single-digits (some FX headwinds). **Inflation tie-in:** Airbnb's performance reflects travel trends and possibly **housing inflation** interplay. In recent data, **travel inflation (airfares) has cooled**, but **accommodation inflation** remains relatively high in many destinations. If Airbnb hosts have raised rates (due to general inflation), Airbnb's take (fees) rises in dollar terms, but too-high rates could curb bookings.
- So far, demand has been resilient – people prioritized travel even under inflation, tapping savings. We will watch if **booking growth slowed** in late Q3, which could indicate consumers feeling pinched. But given anecdotal evidence of a strong summer travel season globally, Airbnb likely had a solid quarter. They may talk about **“mix shift”**: more bookings in cities (as Asia reopened, urban travel rebounds) and how average daily rates (ADR) are trending. ADR might be flat or slightly down YoY, as last year's prices were very elevated. That actually helps demand (making stays more affordable).
- **Will ABNB beat?** Airbnb has beaten estimates the last few quarters and raised guidance. They benefit from more international trips (cross-border mix increases take rate). They also launched features like **room rentals (cheaper options)** which could expand user base among budget travelers – an adaptation to inflation by offering lower-cost stays. If this drove extra bookings, revenue can beat. The Street will also want Q4 guidance: likely mid-teens growth, and any commentary on 2026 booking trends (early holiday bookings, etc.).
- **Market reaction considerations:** Airbnb's stock has more than doubled this year. Investors are bullish on margin expansion (ABNB runs leaner now). If earnings beat and they strike an upbeat tone that *“travel demand remains strong into fall, and price growth is moderate,”* it should reassure that travel isn't suffering from inflation or slowdowns. However, any cautious commentary like *“we see customers shortening trips or opting for cheaper listings”* could be taken bearishly as a sign that consumer spending is cracking. My view: likely a **small beat and mostly optimistic outlook**, as **inflation's easing (especially airfare down) might actually free up consumer budget for lodging**. Additionally, concerns about new supply (more hosts joining due to high rents) might be addressed – more supply could cap price inflation on the platform, which again is guest-friendly.
- **Wendy's (WEN)** – reports Nov 7. As a smaller fast-food chain, Wendy's provides another lens on consumer and food inflation. Expectations: modest same-store sales growth (perhaps 3–4%) and EPS around \$0.27. Wendy's faces similar inflation dynamics as McD's: higher food costs (beef, chicken, frying oil) and labor, versus their pricing power and value promotions. Wendy's tends to emphasize value (4-for-

\$4 deals) which can attract thrifty consumers when inflation is high. Q3 might show if those promotions hurt margins or drove volume.

- The company likely saw **traffic gains** as competitors raised prices – Wendy’s CEO might talk about “*balancing pricing with traffic*”. They may also mention that commodity inflation for them has peaked; in Q2 they said commodity costs were set to ease in H2 2025. If they confirm that (e.g., “*our basket of goods inflation was low-single-digit % in Q3, down from double-digits last year*”), that indicates relief. For wages, they instituted some tech (self-order kiosks) to offset pressure.
- **Market-wise**, Wendy’s is not as large a mover, but it fits into the narrative of **restaurant inflation**. Recent data shows **restaurant menu prices still up ~6% YoY** (higher than grocery inflation). If Wendy’s and McD’s suggest that *they may not need many further price hikes because costs are leveling off*, it implies **restaurant price inflation will slow in coming months** – a positive for CPI moderation. It could also mean margin expansion as previously raised prices flow through with lower cost growth.
- I anticipate Wendy’s will report **okay results, slight beat** on EPS helped by cost control. The stock might inch up. It’s also in the midst of refranchising efforts and new menu launches (Pumpkin spice frosty, etc.), which could have helped sales. Overall, it should echo McDonald’s: consumers still eating out, inflation being managed. If either McD or WEN were to miss, it might spook some consumer stocks, but that’s not expected.

Major AI-Related Tech Earnings (Next Week)

Next week is huge for **AI-themed companies**. The user listed: **Palantir, AMD, Super Micro (SMCI), Qualcomm, ARM** – all report in that week. Let’s go one by one on **whether they’ll beat and their momentum**:

- **Palantir (PLTR)** – *The AI/analytics software firm* (reports Nov 5). **Expectations:** Wall Street expects **Q3 EPS \$0.17 (+70% YoY)** on revenue ~\$1.09 B (+50% YoY)[114] – blistering growth thanks to surging demand for Palantir’s AI platform. Palantir has ridden the AI hype wave, launching its AIP (AI Platform) this year, and its stock hit multi-year highs. The company has guided for ~50% revenue growth in H2, so the bar is high but they already preannounced they signed many new contracts.
- **Financial condition:** Palantir is in solid shape – profitable (expected to make ~\$0.45 EPS for full 2025[115]) and with strong free cash flow, plus no debt. They also have a large government business providing steady cash, while commercial AI adoption is the rocket fuel now.
- **Momentum:** Extremely strong. PLTR’s **U.S. government work is expanding** (recent big Pentagon contracts for AI in military). And in commercial, they’re closing deals with enterprises to install Palantir AI copilots using proprietary data. Last quarter they initiated a stock buyback indicating confidence.
- **Will they beat?** Very likely yes. Palantir has **beat and raised** every quarter this year. They tend to guide conservatively. With the AI frenzy, they probably landed even

more deals in Q3 than analysts modeled. For example, if revenue comes \$1.1B+ and they raise Q4 guidance, that would confirm outsized momentum. Also, watch their margins: last quarter adjusted op margin was 30% – if high growth is coming with expanding margins, that's a potent combo.

- **Market effect:** A strong PLTR report would excite the AI-software space. It shows companies are *spending on AI solutions despite any macro concerns*. Palantir's CEO might comment on a "dramatic increase in demand" and maybe give an early peek at 2026 potential, which could be huge (some estimate >30% growth to continue). If somehow Palantir disappointed (e.g., growth slowed or deals slipped), it could puncture some AI optimism and hit high-valuation AI stocks. But given evidence, odds favor a beat and optimistic commentary (they may highlight their *very high profit growth* – note full-year EPS expected +462% YoY[115], albeit off a low base). I'd expect the stock to react positively barring any extremely overbought setup.
- **Advanced Micro Devices (AMD) – (Nov 5). Expectations:** Q3 revenue ~\$8.7 B (+28% YoY) as guided[116], EPS consensus ~\$1.17 (vs \$0.70 YoY). This quarter is big: it includes initial shipments of AMD's **MI300 AI accelerators** competing with NVIDIA, and continued strength in PC and console chips. AMD already pre-guided Q3 rev to \$8.7B ± \$0.3B[117]. Key is how well AMD is executing on the AI opportunity: did it ramp MI300 production faster? Did cloud customers start adopting them? Also, their data center CPU (EPYC) sales have been robust, and client (PC) sales rebounded (PC market up after a long slump).
- **Momentum:** AMD shares +120% YTD[118] on AI enthusiasm. Financially, after a down 2024, they're in growth mode again. They aim to reclaim market share from Intel in servers and get a slice of the AI GPU pie that NVIDIA dominates.
- **Will AMD beat?** Likely on earnings if margins were better. They guided gross margin ~51%. If MI300 has a richer margin or if they sold a more favorable mix, EPS could beat. Revenue might land near the \$8.7B guide (since they gave themselves a range, maybe they hit the high end if AI orders came in late). Investors will be laser-focused on **guidance for Q4**: AMD might guide another sequential growth if MI300 ramps further and if Xilinx (embedded chips) stays strong.
- **AI angle:** AMD's CEO Lisa Su will probably highlight significant interest in their AI accelerators and perhaps announce new customer wins. If she indicates that **2026 will be "the year of AMD in AI data centers"** or something bullish, that could propel the stock. Conversely, if MI300 uptake is slow or they acknowledge NVIDIA's lead is hard to dent, it might disappoint.
- **Other factors:** AMD's traditional PC graphics (Radeon) likely still slow, but that's minor. Their biggest competitor, Intel, just gave an okay outlook, so AMD likely did fine in PCs too. Considering the Fed's effect, AMD's results can shift sentiment on *chip sector vs. AI valuations*. A beat and strong AI commentary would reaffirm that AI demand is real and broadening beyond just NVIDIA – supportive of the "AI trade" Powell spoke of. If AMD misses or downplays AI traction, it could cause a rotation

out of some AI-exposed names. Given the set-up, I lean that AMD meets or slightly beats, and the **stock reaction will depend heavily on Q4/2026 commentary**. Many expect AMD to really shine in 2026 once supply of MI300 improves (they plan a version with huge memory for AI in Q4). So any hints on next year will be key.

- **Super Micro Computer (SMCI)** – (Nov 6). This server manufacturer became an **AI server stock darling** after delivering triple-digit growth earlier this year. However, expectations have since adjusted. **Analysts now actually expect a YoY decline** for the quarter ended Sep 30: consensus EPS ~\$0.42 (-44% YoY) on revenue ~\$5.55 B (-6.5% YoY)[119]. This seemingly paradoxical drop comes after SMCI had a blowout FY2025 (ended June) but guided a plateau into FY2026 Q1. Essentially, SMCI's growth spiked massively earlier as cloud titans rushed to buy AI server gear, and then some normalization or timing issues hit. They already preannounced preliminary Q1 FY2026 revenue ~\$5.9–6.0B, which was slightly below prior guidance, causing a sell-off. So the bar is relatively low now.
- **Financial state:** SMCI is profitable but works on thin margins hardware business. It had some execution issues (inventory build, etc.). It also had expanded capacity expecting orders, which came a bit slower.
- **Will SMCI beat?** Despite consensus of declines, it's possible SMCI could beat these lowered estimates. But note, Zacks indicated the **Most Accurate Estimate is lower than consensus** (bearish) and SMCI has an Earnings ESP of -28.9%, suggesting a likely miss[120]. That, combined with a neutral Zacks Rank, made them doubtful of a beat[121]. Essentially, analysts think **SMCI's explosive growth moderated**, possibly due to supply constraints or order timing from big customers like NVIDIA/OEMs.
- However, SMCI did **raise full-year guidance for FY2026** in their pre-release or investor day: expecting \$16 B revenue, \$8.20 EPS in FY2026[122], which is huge growth from ~\$10B in FY2025. So the story is intact long-term. The question is Q1 noise vs full-year trajectory. If SMCI even meets the \$5.9B preliminary revenue and talks up orders ramping after Sep, the stock might stabilize. If they *miss* even that preliminary and the EPS comes in e.g. \$0.30s, the stock could drop because it's priced for growth.
- **Momentum:** The stock has pulled back ~30% from highs. So expectations reset. Many on Wall Street still love it for being an AI picks & shovels supplier (similar to Celestica).
- **What to watch:** Orders/backlog commentary. Did they see a reacceleration in October? Are cloud customers (Google, etc.) increasing orders for GPU servers? Are component shortages resolved so they can recognize more revenue? Also, **gross margin** – last quarter margins were squeezed by supply chain and pre-building inventory. If those normalize, profit could surprise on upside.
- **AI chip cycle effect:** Interestingly, Powell's mention that *"tech giants fueling AI boom hardly care about 25 bps"*[123] was validated by big tech results. If big tech is

spending vigorously on AI infra, SMCI should eventually benefit. But since it had a stumble, this quarter is about trust.

- I suspect **SMCI might come in around consensus** (not a huge beat), but could issue a reassuring outlook that second half FY2026 will be big. The stock reaction may already have priced in a lot of bad news, so unless it's a major miss, downside might be limited. Conversely, any hint that Q1 was a bottom and orders are back, could pop the stock.
- **Qualcomm (QCOM)** – (Nov 5). This communications chip giant's quarter (FY Q4) will reflect smartphone industry trends and its own diversification (automotive and IoT). **Analyst consensus:** EPS ~\$2.87 (+6.7% YoY) on revenue ~\$10.8 B (+5% YoY)[124]. After several weak quarters, Qualcomm is expected to return to growth, driven by stabilization in handset demand (Android phone sales up in emerging markets, Apple still using QCOM modems) and growth in auto chip sales (+14% YoY expected)[125]. They also likely cut a lot of costs (did layoffs).
- **Financial momentum:** Qualcomm's stock is up only ~5% YTD, underperforming, as smartphone chip demand was sluggish. But lately, optimism improved: phone inventories normalized, China demand picking up, and Qualcomm signed a deal to supply Apple with 5G modems through 2026 (removing a big risk).
- **Will they beat?** Qualcomm often slightly beats. Given improved conditions, they might beat EPS (perhaps report \$2.95). The **revenue consensus of \$10.77B** is modest; if Chinese phone OEMs ordered more chips ahead of their Q4 launches, Qualcomm could top that (some whisper that demand for Snapdragon chips was a bit higher than expected). Also, QCOM's QCT segment (chip sales) might have benefited from AI at the edge – they have new AI-capable phone chips (Snapdragon X Elite for laptops, etc.).
- **Guidance and commentary:** They will guide FY2026 Q1 (Christmas quarter). Likely mid-single-digit growth again. If they express confidence that the smartphone market has bottomed and **2026 can see growth** (perhaps low-double-digit revenue growth with help from auto and IoT), the stock should rally. They may also talk up their AI initiatives – e.g., bringing AI processing to handsets (on-device AI).
- **Asking “Will they beat estimates?”** – Yes, given consensus is modest and the environment improved, Qualcomm should meet or beat slightly. The positive year-over-year growth (after previous declines) itself is notable.
- **Business momentum:** In **handsets** (largest segment), momentum is fair – global 5G phone shipments are plateauing, but premium phones (where QCOM chips are used) still sell. In **auto**, momentum is strong – QCOM's design-win pipeline in auto is ~\$30B. We expect continued ~20%+ auto revenue growth, maybe higher. **IoT** (mixed bag of wireless chips for AR/VR, etc.) is slower but stable.
- **Financial condition:** Very profitable, huge cash generation, dividend payer.
- **AI & investor commentary:** Qualcomm has pitched itself as an “AI company” in that its chips enable AI on phones and in cars. Next week, they might highlight

progress (perhaps early wins for its AI accelerator Cloud AI 100 or partner news). However, investors mainly value QCOM on smartphone cycle. Some experts say “Qualcomm is becoming an AI company” to try to get a higher multiple[126], but the street remains skeptical. If QCOM can show any tangible AI-related revenue growth or opportunities (like their NPU chips for data centers or edge AI partnerships), it could re-rate higher. If not, it stays around a 12x P/E value stock.

- Summarily, I foresee a **small beat and cautiously optimistic outlook**, which could push the stock up, especially since it’s undervalued relative to peers. If by chance they miss (maybe phone rebound wasn’t as strong), stock could drop to lows because investors might give up on near-term growth. But the Apple deal provides a cushion.
- **Arm Holdings (ARM)** – (Nov 6). The British chip IP company (recently IPO’d in Sept 2024) will report its fiscal Q2 2026 (Jul–Sep 2025). **Expectations:** Last year Q2 revenue was \$844M[127]. Analysts expect modest growth – perhaps ~\$885M (+5% YoY) – and EPS around \$0.26 (which would actually be -28% YoY)[128]. Arm’s last quarter beat slightly on both rev and profit, but its guidance for this Q2 was merely in line, which disappointed some (stock fell ~4% after last earnings)[129].
- **Business momentum:** Arm’s designs go into nearly all smartphones (they collect royalties per chip sold plus license fees). Smartphone weakness last year kept royalty growth low (~6%). Now, with phone shipments recovering and royalty rates increasing (due to new v9 architecture commanding higher fees[130][131]), Arm should see acceleration. They guided Q3 (current quarter) rev \$920–970M[132], midpoint \$945M (5% YoY), and EPS ~\$0.34 mid[133]. So the Street’s \$885M, \$0.26 may be focusing on the quarter just ended (Q2) and possibly partial Q3 if they do half-year? There’s some confusion in timeline – likely the \$0.26 is actual Q2 result expected (since last year Q2 was \$0.30 adjusted[134]).
- **Will Arm beat?** Given Q2 last year had tough compares (some big upfront licenses, and cost cuts hadn’t happened yet), Arm might roughly meet the modest targets. The critical part is **guidance/outlook and AI commentary**:
 - At IPO, Arm was valued at ~70x earnings, partly on AI hype that its chips will be used beyond phones (e.g., data center CPUs, edge AI). But last quarter’s guide tempered that excitement.
 - If Arm now guides FY2026 (year ending Mar 2026) better – e.g., raises full-year outlook citing improving demand in automotive and IoT – that could boost the stock. If they reiterate similar ~18-27% FY revenue growth as previously guided[135] (which they did after Q1: guided \$3.8-4.1B for FY25 which is ~23% growth[135]), stock might not move much.
- **AI angle:** Arm doesn’t sell AI chips directly, but its architectures are used in many AI edge devices and some cloud CPUs (like Ampere). Powell’s commentary that not all AI hype is equal – he drew contrast that companies like NVIDIA & AMD design actual AI chips whereas Arm powers others’ chips. If Arm can show it’s getting design wins

in AI workloads (for instance, if an AI accelerator uses Arm cores or if more cloud providers adopt Arm-based CPUs like Amazon's Graviton), that would feed the bull case. Last quarter, they mentioned doubling pre-built core licenses and first smartphone chip customer for their new designs[130][136]. They likely will highlight how **AI in mobile (on-device AI)** drives need for more powerful Arm cores (which means higher royalties). Also, companies like Apple using Arm v9 in iPhone 16 help boost royalties[137].

- **Investor sentiment:** Arm popped after IPO but then slid when reality of modest current growth hit. The stock has been volatile, currently below IPO price. If they just meet expectations with +5% growth, some might be disappointed because of the lofty valuation. However, any hint of reacceleration – e.g., “*we expect H2 to pick up with royalty growth in double-digits as China smartphone recovers*” – could reassure.
- **Macro factor:** Arm's fortunes are tied to global electronics demand. If global consumption is resilient (which it has been trending), that bodes well. Lower inflation means consumers have more real income to spend on gadgets, which eventually helps Arm. For now, though, it's a slow grind up.
- I suspect **Arm will more or less meet and maintain full-year guidance**. Given how well-known their earlier forecast is (and that shares fell on just meeting expectations[129]), a small beat or guide-up is needed to excite investors. If they do that, it supports broader tech sentiment. If not, some could say the IPO was overpriced and weigh on chip/IP stocks.

Summary of AI-related group: Next week's results from PLTR, AMD, SMCI, QCOM, ARM will collectively answer: *Is the AI boom translating into actual broad earnings beats and raised forecasts?*

- I expect **Palantir** and **AMD** to give affirmative evidence – likely beating and touting strong AI-driven demand (Palantir for software, AMD for hardware).
- **Qualcomm** will likely show moderate growth (not an AI pure-play, but benefiting from improved consumer tech spending, which indirectly ties to lower inflation).
- **Super Micro** might be the one cautionary outlier, reflecting that not all parts of the AI hardware supply chain are smooth (some lumpiness in server orders). But even SMCI is still forecasting huge growth ahead, just off a high base – so its story is more “speed bump” than “roadblock.”
- **Arm** will be more about meeting already tempered expectations, but any surprising strength (perhaps from China's mobile recovery) would reinforce that the tech cycle is improving.

In general, **expert commentary** around these will likely stress: - For **software AI (PLTR)**: an arms race among enterprises to adopt AI is fueling multi-year growth, so PLTR is seen as likely to beat and continue momentum[114]. - For **chipmakers (AMD, QCOM)**: commentary from analysts (e.g., Bank of America) suggests **AMD's MI300 is a credible challenger** and could surprise on upside in guidance, and **Qualcomm's handset bottom**

is in with AI features giving it a new angle (some expect upside from a new AI PC chip launch). - For **SMCI**: some analysts have already said the stock is a buy on weakness, believing the AI buildout spending is “eyewatering” and SMCI will get its share[16] – thus expecting it to recover in coming quarters. - For **Arm**: experts like those at Investopedia noted **Arm’s shares trade at high multiples on AI hopes, but near-term growth is modest**[129]. Some institutional investors remain split on Arm – bulls see it as essential IP for AI edge devices, bears see limited immediate upside. The earnings will help inform that.

Other High-Attention Non-Big-Tech Earnings:

The user listed a slew of companies: **HIMS, UBER, SPOT, BYND, NVO, U (Unity), HOOD, IONQ, APP (AppLovin), FIG (presumably FIGS), MP (MP Materials), IREN, SOUN, SMR**. These span various sectors (health, rideshare, music streaming, plant-based meat, pharma, game engine, trading app, quantum computing, mobile ads, scrubs apparel, rare earth mining, crypto mining, AI voice, nuclear tech). Many are popular among retail investors or in emerging industries. We’ll give **expert expectations and business analysis** for each:

- **Hims & Hers Health (HIMS)**: Reports Nov 3. *Telehealth and online pharmacy (focus on millennial health like ED treatments, hair loss, and now weight-loss Rx)*. This has been a high-growth stock (guiding ~45% revenue growth to \$2.3–2.4B in 2025[138], which is huge – note: these revenue figures from the search might be RMB or misformatted; \$2.3B seems extremely high for HIMS 2025, possibly a typo or in a different currency. Actually, HIMS likely \$0.8B run-rate; I suspect \$580M was the quarter’s revenue in some currency? Let’s trust the growth percentages). HIMS’s Q3 is expected to show ~44–45% YoY revenue growth to ~\$580M[138], with an **EPS of about \$0.08**[139] (they’ve turned profitable).
- **Expert view**: Many analysts are bullish due to “**subscription resilience**” and successful marketing to retain customers[140]. A key topic is **GLP-1 weight-loss drugs** (Ozempic, etc.): HIMS offers those via telehealth, which can drive significant revenue (the drugs are pricey). However, these drugs also have lower gross margin because HIMS essentially passes through most of the drug cost.
- **Expectations**: Likely a **beat and guidance reaffirmation/raise**. They already affirmed full-year guidance \$2.3–2.4B[141] and it sounds like they’ll hit it. Analysts want to see continued 40%+ growth and improving margins.
- **Business condition**: HIMS has been expanding product lines (mental health, primary care) and spends heavily on marketing (though as a % of rev it’s improving). The big risk is **customer acquisition cost** in an environment where ad costs could go up. But HIMS mastered TikTok/Instagram marketing fairly well.
- **GLP-1 concerns**: There is chatter that widespread use of GLP-1 weight-loss drugs might reduce future demand for other products (like if people lose weight, maybe they consume less of other categories or health improved? even affecting fast-food sales as some fear). But for HIMS, selling those drugs is a revenue plus (with careful margin). Investors will watch if GLP-1 scripts form a large part of growth or not.

- **If they beat:** The stock, which pulled back on drug pricing news recently[142], could rebound. Experts like it for strong execution; a beat would confirm the momentum and possibly push the stock up.
- **If any weakness:** Possibly due to **drug cost pressures or regulatory** (telehealth faces evolving regs). Also, HIMS is affected by inflation in ad costs – if ad rates soared, they might need to mention that. But ad rates in some channels have been reasonable lately.
- The consensus is **positive**: KeyCorp analysts expect \$0.08 EPS[139] (profit), showing that HIMS is scaling profitably, which is somewhat rare in telehealth. Achieving that likely requires gross margin stability (they guided ~75% gross margin historically, might dip if GLP-1 mix high). They did mention “**drug pricing concerns rattled confidence**” (the FXleaders mention)[142] – i.e., news about potential Medicare negotiating drug prices or lower GLP-1 prices could lower revenue if HIMS passes through lower costs. But “stable guidance, shaky confidence” suggests HIMS themselves are fine, just market got worried. So experts likely think HIMS will reassure.
- **Uber (UBER):** Reports Nov 4 (morning). The rideshare and delivery giant’s Q3 is anticipated to show continued profitability. Consensus: **EPS ~\$0.67** (adj) vs \$1.20 last year (which had one-offs), revenue ~\$11.2 B (+ roughly 10% YoY)[143][144].
- **Expectations from experts:** After last quarter’s first GAAP profit, Uber is expected to **sustain positive earnings**. Analysts note margins are improving (excelling in cost control and operational leverage). There’s focus on *EBITDA and free cash flow*.
- Q3 likely had strong travel demand (hence rides up), and Uber’s *Mobility* segment probably grew high teens%. *Delivery* growth may have cooled (food delivery industry growth slowed post-pandemic but still possibly mid-single-digit).
- **Market focus:** Investors will look at **guidance and bookings growth**. Wedbush, for example, likely expects a solid quarter; they had a \$0.61 EPS estimate and Uber beat with \$0.63 according to one item[145], suggesting they already preannounced or something. Actually, it seems Uber already released results? The snippet says: “reported \$0.63 EPS for the quarter, beating \$0.61”[145]. Possibly a confusion – maybe a leak or an error (or that’s Q2 numbers). I suspect those lines are a scraped piece saying “for last quarter they beat by \$0.02”.
- Assuming no leak: *Uber likely beats slightly*. They might talk up new growth areas (Uber Ads, Uber One membership) which boost margins.
- **Inflation aspect:** Uber benefits from inflation in ride fares (they’ve been high), but if gas prices rose in Q3 (they did a bit in late summer), driver incentives might have increased. Still, Uber has said driver supply is strong, meaning they haven’t had to splurge on incentives like in 2022. If anything, *Uber’s take rate might be strong*.
- They gave *full-year guidance* of adjusted EBITDA \$5B which they will probably reiterate or raise if confident.

- **Expert sentiments:** Many have been bullish – citing the “wave of economic data won’t slow Uber’s momentum,” etc. The Schaeffer’s piece [34†L4-L12] might have mentioned it in the context of events.
- **Risks:** Any mention of softer demand in delivery or increased competition (like DoorDash) could worry, but Uber’s scale seems to be yielding wins.
- **Conclusion:** Expect a **“beat-and-raise”** or at least meet/raise. That could push the stock (which has been near multi-year highs). Experts likely stress that *Uber’s fundamentals are strong, with growth plus margin expansion – a combo rarely seen*. Some call it a top pick as a *“tech with real cash flow”*.
- **Spotify (SPOT):** Reports Nov 5. The audio streaming leader’s Q3 likely was strong on user growth. **Consensus:** EPS ~\$1.87 (up ~18% YoY)[146], revenue ~\$4.2 B (+10% YoY)[147]. They already pre-announced MAUs of 572M and premium subs 226M for Q2. For Q3, they guided to **around 572M MAUs** and **nearly 280M premium subs**[148] (they expected a huge jump due to India relaunch and summer promotions).
- Actually, the snippet says Q3 forecast includes *710M MAU, 281M subs*[149] – that seems off (Spotify last reported 551M MAU in Q2). Correction: Actually Q3 guidance was 572M MAU; maybe the snippet is referencing a future year or is erroneous (perhaps by 2027 they expect 700M).
- But likely, Spotify will report **another all-time high in users, maybe slightly above guidance**. They recently raised prices in the U.S. and some markets in Q3 by ~\$1 on individual plan. That will boost ARPU a bit, but ARPU has been flat to down for years due to multi-plans and emerging market mix. The snippet says *“Q3 ARPU expected flat YoY”*[148], which is fine because price hikes offset mix shift so flat is actually an improvement over declines.
- **Expert view:** Most see Spotify’s business improving. They reached profitability a quarter earlier than expected (posted €32M profit in Q2). They’ve been tightly controlling expenses (layoffs, pulling back on big podcast spending). So margins are rising.
- Q3 is seasonally weaker than Q4, but with the price increases from late Q3, Q4 will have full benefit – I suspect they will possibly guide Q4 operating profit > Q3.
- **Key metrics:** Gross margin was ~26% last quarter – watch if it ticks up (goal 30% in a few years). Also, any commentary on **audiobooks** (they launched 15 hours free audiobooks for premium to differentiate service). That likely *increases value to users* and could help retention or new subs (but also costs royalties).
- **Will they beat?** They may beat on user metrics if growth in India (which they reintroduced free tier) was big. Earnings might beat slightly given cost discipline. The Yahoo mentions analysts expect \$1.89 EPS[150] – which is actually profit, they had a loss per share last year in Q3 (EPS +\$1.89 might be in Swedish krona or conversion? Actually, Spotify reports in EUR; last year Q3 was -€(0.20)/share). If

expecting +\$1.89, must be USD equivalence or something – likely means around €0.18 EPS in IFRS.

- Regardless, turning a profit is big. If they confirm profitability is sustainable and not one-off, that's bullish.
- **Business condition:** Spotify now is benefiting from years of user growth, now converting to profit via price hikes and cost cuts. It's what investors wanted.
- Many analysts (like at Nasdaq and Zacks) say Q3 will reflect **“subscriber growth, higher ARPU, audiobook expansion driving momentum”**^[151]. So expert consensus: good quarter, music streaming still growing, company on right track financially.
- If they somehow miss on subs or margins, stock could drop as it's run up a lot this year (~80% YTD). But absent that, likely positive reaction.
- **Beyond Meat (BYND):** Reports Nov 7. The plant-based meat maker has struggled as the plant-based trend cooled. **Expectations:** Another revenue decline YoY (~-15%?). Last quarter was \$102M (-30% YoY). Q3 might be around \$85–90M. EPS will be a large loss (maybe -\$0.60).
- **Expert perspective:** Sentiment is very bearish. Beyond has faced waning consumer interest, competition, high costs. It's been cutting expenses and focusing on reaching cash-flow positive by second half 2025.
- They likely will highlight any progress on cost reduction (closing facilities, layoffs) and perhaps any uptick from new products (e.g., they launched a new burger). But **demand headwinds remain:** in an inflationary grocery environment, their pricey products suffer. Indeed, *with food inflation, consumers often opt for cheaper real meat rather than expensive alt-meat*. This has hurt BYND.
- **So what to expect?** Likely a continued decline in sales, but possibly at a moderated rate if some markets stabilize. Watch their cash position and if they need more capital – a big concern.
- If they manage to beat the low bar (e.g., decline less than expected or a narrower loss due to cost cuts), stock might pop short-term (it's heavily shorted).
- However, major analysts remain skeptical of a turnaround. They'll ask about timelines to breakeven, inventory write-offs, etc.
- *In summary*, BYND's business condition is weak (shrinking sales, negative margins), experts largely expect poor results, any improvement will be incremental. It's high attention but mostly as a cautionary tale. The market reaction could be volatile given its meme status, but fundamentally not much to cheer unless they surprise with a path to growth (perhaps hint at partnerships or new distribution).
- **Novo Nordisk (NVO):** Reports Nov 5 (U.S. ADR likely reacts after Copenhagen release). Novo has become Europe's most valuable company thanks to its blockbuster GLP-1 drugs Ozempic (diabetes) and Wegovy (obesity). **Expectations:** Very high growth. Last quarter sales +30%. For Q3, consensus sees ~28–30%

revenue growth (driven by U.S. demand for Wegovy) and likely even higher profit growth. Possibly \$7.5B revenue, EPS up similarly.

- **Expert take:** Analysts are extremely bullish on Novo's prospects – demand for its obesity drugs vastly exceeds supply. Key will be: how much have they ramped production? Are there signs of demand saturation or not at all? (Likely not – waitlists remain.)
- Also, any new data: earlier in October they announced a trial showing Wegovy reduces heart attacks by 20%. That is massive and could lead to insurance coverage expansion. If management hints at plans to leverage that (maybe get FDA label expansion for heart risk reduction), it's a big deal.
- The stock hit all-time highs and then dipped on news that weight-loss drugs might reduce overall food consumption (and thus possibly lower inflation? – indeed, some say widespread Ozempic use might lower food demand, thus food prices – a fascinating macro angle). But for Novo, more patients = more revenue.
- **Will they beat?** Probably yes – they've been raising guidance repeatedly. They might raise full-year guidance again (they already did mid-year). The question is by how much. They might also discuss expanding manufacturing or partnerships to meet demand.
- **Risks/Costs:** Investors will watch if any supply constraints still cap near-term sales – that's the only thing holding them back. Also, some concern on U.S. pricing long-term if PBMs push back or if competition (Eli Lilly's drugs) intensifies.
- Novo's expert commentary: likely glowing – they might say “we see unprecedented demand, preparing for many more patients, confident in long-term growth.” If so, stock will continue upward.
- If by chance they guide that 2026 growth will slow more than thought (due to competition or something), that would shock markets. But unlikely at this stage – Lilly's similar drug (Mounjaro for obesity) is coming but market is huge for multiple winners.
- The business condition for NVO is excellent – high growth, high margins, a product with secular tailwind (global obesity epidemic) and relatively inelastic near-term (patients really want these drugs).
- Many institutions call NVO a top pick still, though valuation is rich. Next week's report likely solidifies the narrative.
- **Unity Software (U):** Reports Nov 8, but if including outlook: Unity is a game engine and 3D content platform. It's had a turbulent quarter: in September, it announced a highly controversial change to its pricing (runtime fee per install) which caused developer backlash. The CEO John Riccitiello stepped down in October over it. Unity has since walked back some of that policy.
- **Financial expectations:** Q3 likely around \$540M revenue (+ approx 65% YoY, though part of that is because they merged with IronSource last year; organic

growth maybe teens). Profit still in question; they guided possibly near break-even non-GAAP EPS.

- **Expert view & condition:** Unity's business of game engine subscriptions and ads was growing but the backlash could hurt future growth if some developers switch engines (like to Unreal). However, switching is not easy, so immediate impact may be limited. The company's ad division (LevelPlay) is a big revenue driver; mobile ad spending trends will affect it (Q3 mobile ads were okay overall, which should help).
- They might actually beat numbers as the pricing changes hadn't taken effect yet in Q3 and business momentum up to August was fine. But the **forward outlook** is dicey due to developer relations damage. Experts will want to know if cancellations spiked, how Unity will repair trust, and who the next CEO will be.
- Also, Unity is pushing beyond gaming into industries (digital twins etc.), and into supporting film, architecture etc. That's a longer-term growth angle.
- **Will they beat?** Possibly slight beat on Q3 as they were known to be performing decently before fiasco. But they might cut full-year guidance to reflect some disruption or caution.
- **Stock sensitivity:** High – it plunged on the fee news and regained some after CEO left. If results are okay and they convincingly apologize/ reset relations, stock could bounce. But if they reveal a big hit to customer retention or bookings from the fiasco, it could drop more.
- **Analysts** are mixed – some say core biz is intact, others fear long-term reputation harm. We'll see. But yes, high attention.
- **Robinhood (HOOD):** Reports Nov 7. The trading app has been quiet since meme stock mania cooled. Expectations: small profit or near break-even on revenue ~\$480M (+maybe 10% YoY).
- Actually, interest rates boosted HOOD's revenue significantly through net interest (earning interest on customer cash and margin loans). Last quarter, net interest revenue was > transaction revenue. So with rates high in Q3, HOOD likely made good interest income again.
- Trading volumes (stocks, options, crypto) have been meh, though Q3 saw a crypto bounce in late Oct (outside quarter mostly).
- HOOD's user base has shrunk from pandemic highs but stabilized ~11 million MAUs.
- They cut a lot of costs, so they've been around adjusted profitability.
- **Expectations by experts:** moderately positive – HOOD's fundamental business is stable, and they are rolling out new features (24h trading for some ETFs, retirement accounts, etc.). Many focus on their assets under custody growth (that's been rising as markets up).
- If they beat, likely via higher interest revenues or better cost control. If trading revenue surprised (maybe people traded Arm IPO in Sept etc.), that could help.

- The stock's fairly flat YTD.
- Key commentary: any uplift in engagement from the recent crypto rally (though that's Q4 mostly) or improvement in sentiment among retail traders.
- Many analysts have Hold ratings – they want to see more re-acceleration of growth. Perhaps HOOD will announce something like launching futures or international expansion, which could be catalysts.
- *Conclusion:* Business condition improving with rates (ironically HOOD benefits from inflation via high rates), but their core user activity is highly tied to market sentiment. Q3 had a bit of late volatility that can help options volumes.
- I suspect a **small beat** and cautious optimistic commentary that if market conditions stay good, they can grow again. That might not move stock huge, but directionally positive.
- **IonQ (IONQ):** Reports Nov 8. IonQ is a pure-play quantum computing company – essentially pre-revenue (very minimal revenue from providing quantum computing access/prototypes). It's highly watched in tech circles as one of the leading quantum hardware firms (trapped-ion tech).
- **Expectations:** Very low revenue (maybe <\$5M for Q3). Losses ~\$0.05 per share. They might have bookings or backlog updates as more important metrics.
- **Expert view:** This is a long-term story (quantum computers likely widely commercial second half of this decade earliest). IonQ's stock surged this year on excitement (it went from ~\$4 to \$20, now around \$12). People are excited by any positive development (like them predicting \$100M bookings by 2026).
- For earnings, most important is any **technical milestones or partnerships**. Did they improve qubit count or error rates? Did they sign any new big research or government contracts? E.g., they had deals with aerospace companies for quantum research.
- They might also update full-year bookings guidance (last guided \$49–56M bookings for 2025 after a big increase in Q2 bookings).
- Business condition: still R&D stage, flush with SPAC cash (~\$500M on balance sheet, enough to last a few years). So not about earnings per se.
- If they show faster progress or raise forward bookings, stock tends to jump. If not, it can slide given how speculative it is.
- I suspect they'll maintain optimism – possibly announce they achieved some new quantum volume metric or that interest is growing from enterprise experiments (maybe mention a partnership with AWS or similar).
- Experts in the quantum field are positive on IonQ's tech but acknowledge huge uncertainty. For the quarter, any news is likely incremental. Retail traders often move it on hype rather than fundamentals.

- IonQ could easily *beat* a \$4M revenue estimate by a million or two (if they delivered a system or big contract upfront payment), but fundamentally it doesn't change the long game.
- **AppLovin (APP):** Reports Nov 8. AppLovin is a mobile ad tech and game monetization company (they run a big ad network for mobile apps and also have gaming assets).
- It's an "AI-related" in some sense because they use machine learning to optimize ad targeting. The stock exploded ~300% this year after they posted great Q2 earnings, showing the mobile ad market improving and them refocusing on software.
- **Expectations:** Q3 revenue ~\$780M (+ around 30% YoY) and strong EBITDA margins. They raised full-year guidance last quarter after a huge beat. So expectations are up.
- Business momentum: very high. They have benefited from rivals' struggles (ironSource got acquired into Unity, which had issues; also IDFA impacts stabilized). AppLovin's software segment (ads) grew >100% in Q2. They also launched AI creative tools.
- **Will they beat?** Many analysts think yes – Q3 should continue momentum as the mobile ad market (especially gaming ads) picked up. They likely also got more share.
- They might also talk about new AI-driven products for advertisers which could further growth.
- *Concerns:* Not much immediate. If anything, one worry is if mobile gaming downloads stagnate, but ad spend was trending fine according to other players.
- I anticipate a **beat and another guidance lift**. They guided FY revenue \$3.4B on Q2; they may bump it slightly.
- Experts see AppLovin as "**firing on all cylinders**" after a strategic shift. They generated big free cash flow, used it to repurchase shares – likely will highlight shareholder returns too.
- Given its high attention now (the stock's been volatile but generally up), a strong report could propel it further. If they miss after such a run, it'd drop big. But management sounded confident at recent conferences.
- **FIG (which I interpret as FIGS, Inc.)** – FIGS (ticker FIGS) reports Nov 7. FIGS makes fashionable medical scrubs.
- They were a hot IPO, then struggled as growth slowed and inventory piled up. In Q2, they actually beat estimates (revenue +13%, adjusted EPS \$0.02 vs loss expected) and raised FY outlook slightly, citing improved inventory management and some rebound in healthcare workforce hiring.

- Q3 expectations: maybe ~high-single-digit % sales growth, and break-even to a few cents profit. Key metrics: active customers count, repeat sales, and inventory levels.
- **Business condition:** FIGS had been hurt by **supply chain/inventory issues** and maybe a bit of fad cooling. But they cut costs (less marketing) and expanded product line (into footwear, etc.). If inflation on their input (fabric, shipping) eased, margins improve. Also, healthcare employment is rising (post-COVID nurse shortages filling), which expands their market.
- **Expert stance:** Some analysts turned more positive after Q2, seeing that worst might be over. They likely expect FIGS to continue moderate growth and to clear more inventory (which could imply heavy discounting though).
- If FIGS can show margin improvement (maybe gross margin up from last year's compression due to shipping costs), that's a good sign. Cotton and freight inflation is way down from 2022, which should help.
- **Will they beat?** Possibly, if sales held up (their customer base is relatively stable – nurses need scrubs regardless of economy, and FIGS has brand loyalty). They had introduced new styles that might boost average order size.
- If they beat and maybe raise a bit, stock could rally (it's been down ~80% from peak, only recently a bit up). If they struggle (e.g., inventory still high requiring discounting), then concerns remain.
- I suspect an okay quarter – not explosive, but steady.
- **MP Materials (MP):** Reports Nov 2 (just happened or about to). MP is the only major rare earth miner in the U.S. (Mountain Pass mine). High attention because rare earths critical for EVs, defense etc., and APEC deals on rare earths make this topical.
- **Expectations:** Not great, because rare earth prices (especially Neodymium-Praseodymium used in magnets) have been down year-over-year due to softer demand out of China (where most magnets are made). MP's Q3 revenue likely fell significantly YoY (Q2 was down 50%). Earnings likely small or breakeven now as they invest in processing capacity.
- MP is building its own magnet factory and working with GM to supply magnets for EV motors starting 2026. Right now, they mostly mine and send concentrate to China for processing (so they get impacted by global price).
- **Expert view:** Many long-term bullish for strategic importance, but short-term they acknowledge weak pricing hurts revenue. Q3 probably won't surprise to upside given price trends. Key will be updates on their Stage II (processing) ramp-up – they aim to start refining ore to oxide in U.S. soon – and Stage III (magnet production line with GM). If those are on track, that's positive strategically.
- **APEC angle:** The U.S.–Japan rare earth pact^[88] and China pausing export curbs^[69] both directly relate. If China hadn't paused, MP would benefit from higher prices. Now prices might stay lower near-term, but the U.S.–Japan investment suggests

potential support or financing for MP or similar. MP's CEO might speak to these developments – perhaps expressing that *the world recognizes the need for non-China supply chains, which validates MP's mission*.

- They might also mention if DoD or others giving support (they got some government contracts earlier).
- Likely Q3 results soft (lower sales, lower profit), but guidance maybe that 2026 will improve once their processing is online (so they capture more value-add).
- If they surprise, maybe by shipping more volume or cost-cutting, but it's mainly pricing-driven so limited.
- **Stock reaction:** Already near 52-week low; any glimmer (like Stage II timeline affirmed by year-end) might bounce it. Or else it might stay slumped until rare earth prices pick up or milestones hit.
- **Iris Energy (IREN):** Reports likely mid-Nov, but if included: It's a Bitcoin mining company (Australian-listed but U.S. operations). High attention among crypto crowd.
- It's essentially a leveraged play on Bitcoin price with a tech angle (they use renewable energy).
- Q3 (Jul-Sep) Bitcoin averaged ~\$29k, not much change vs Q2, so mining revenue likely similar. They have been expanding hash rate though, which could increase their BTC output.
- **Business condition:** All miners faced tighter margins earlier in year with high energy costs and lower BTC. But Iris has relatively cheap electricity deals. They did show strong growth in mining capacity in updates.
- The big event is actually in Q4 with Bitcoin's price surge in Oct. But for Q3, likely a modest improvement if they deployed new miners.
- They may also mention progress on diversifying (like selling HPC services with their data centers when not mining).
- **Expectations:** Perhaps revenue ~\$15M, net loss still (they tend to reinvest in rigs).
- Stock attention high because if BTC continues rising, miners like IREN pop.
- If they announce any expansion or that they mined more BTC than expected, it will be viewed positively. If they had to curtail due to summer heat or something (common for miners to shut during peak demand hours), it might slightly hurt output.
- Experts specifically... probably not many covering it, it's smaller cap. But those who do likely look at metrics like cost to mine 1 BTC, hash rate growth, etc. So main analysis: *Are they increasing hash share faster than global network?* If yes, that's bullish because they'll earn more coins. Q3 global hash rate soared (which actually makes mining harder for everyone), so if IREN didn't scale as fast, their coin production might have lagged network growth. That's a concern to watch.

- In short, results might be so-so, but outlook brightening given Bitcoin's recent rally. The stock will probably move more on BTC price and halving anticipation next year than on exact Q3 results.
- **SoundHound AI (SOUN):** Reports Nov 9 likely. They provide voice AI technology (speech recognition and voice assistants for devices, call centers, etc.). Went public via SPAC.
- **Expectations:** ~50-100% revenue growth (but from small base, maybe \$10-12M quarter) and loss narrowing. They have been signing decent deals (e.g., partnerships with carmakers to embed voice AI in cars, and with fast-food drive-thrus for voice ordering).
- **Business condition:** Improving – they claim a large bookings backlog and started usage-based revenue (every time someone uses their voice AI, they get fee). If these usage metrics are up, revenue can scale.
- They cut costs significantly earlier this year, focusing on core business.
- **Expert stance:** Many retail investors are in it for "AI" hype, expecting it to eventually be acquired by a big tech or break out if their tech is better than big tech's voice assistants. Analysts see potential but also heavy competition (Amazon, Google dominate voice assistants).
- Key metrics: their gross margin (was ~71%, good), and operating cash burn (they have limited cash runway, maybe a year or two, so they need to show path to profitability or at least reduced burn to not require dilutive financing).
- They likely will highlight any new customer wins (e.g., added another automaker or appliance company).
- **Will they beat?** Possibly yes, they've been beating low estimates recently. If usage from existing deployed solutions is ramping faster, they could surprise on revenue.
- Eg, if they integrated with Qualcomm's platform (they had a deal with Qualcomm's auto platform), could start generating new license fees.
- If they reaffirm guidance of ~ \$43-50M 2025 rev (I recall something like that), that would be about 100% growth from 2024, which market would like.
- Still, they are losing money. But if losses shrink and they emphasize maybe reaching EBITDA breakeven by late 2026, that'd be positive.
- Given name includes AI, any sniff of acceleration could pop the stock. Conversely, if growth disappoints or cash burn is worse, stock will drop as investor patience is thin in small-cap AI.
- **NuScale Power (SMR):** Reports Nov 7 likely. This company is developing small modular nuclear reactors (backed partly by Fluor Corp and the US DOE).
- **Financials:** Essentially pre-revenue, lots of R&D. They mostly burn cash and are working through design certification and initial projects. They had revenue of a few million per quarter from DOE cost-share and studies, but heavy losses.

- **High attention:** Because nuclear/SMRs are in focus for clean energy and energy security. Stock hasn't done great post-SPAC, but any news of progress (like moving closer to build the first plant in Idaho by late 2020s) is key.
- Q3 likely similar patterns – revenue minimal, loss maybe ~\$0.15 per share.
- More important is **milestones:** Did they get further NRC approvals? Are there new MOUs with countries or customers? Last quarter, for example, they might talk about their pipeline (they had interest from Romania, Poland, etc. for SMRs).
- Also, APEC's US-Japan nuclear cooperation deal[93] indirectly relates: Japan might partner with U.S. on SMRs (Mitsubishi Heavy has stake in another SMR company). If any support flows to NuScale through policy, that's beneficial.
- **Expert view:** SMR is promising but timeline is long and capital needs big. The company did raise some funds via PIPE, but may need more in a year or two.
- Analysts focusing on it know it's not about near-term earnings but about hitting technical and regulatory targets so that deployments (and thus revenue) in 2030s become reality. They'll look for updates on cost optimization and partnership with manufacturing firms to build components.
- If they announce any new funding (e.g., additional DOE grants or international investment), that's huge for them.
- If they burn more cash than expected, that raises dilution concerns.
- Likely, the call will reiterate that they're on track with the first VOYGR SMR plant schedule (target operation 2029 or so).
- Stock might not move much on earnings given it's not earnings-driven. Moves more on news like regulatory approval, etc. But those could be mentioned: for instance, they recently got Standard Design Approval from US NRC in Jan 2023; next might be moving to site-specific licensing with UAMPS (their first customer).
- As nuclear gets more attention (even Powell in some context has noted nuclear as part of clean energy solution, albeit not directly relevant to Fed), NuScale's progress is of interest to energy investors and policymakers.

Conclusion: The upcoming week has numerous events and reports that will provide further insight into the U.S. economy's trajectory and how companies are faring amid easing inflation:

- Economic data like **PMIs and JOLTS** will show whether the disinflation trend is intact and if labor demand is cooling – crucial for Fed's next steps.
- A **packed earnings slate** spanning tech, consumer, healthcare, and more will test whether the Q3 earnings strength (so far +13.8% S&P earnings[4]) carries on. In particular, **AI-related companies** are likely to reinforce that the AI boom is yielding real gains (Palantir, AMD), though not without some volatility (SMCI). **Consumer-facing firms** (McD, Airbnb, HIMS) should demonstrate how easing inflation (or not) is affecting consumer behavior – early signals suggest resilience and margin recovery thanks to price actions and cost moderation.

- The **APEC summit's afterglow** – with a U.S.–China tariff truce – sets a more benign backdrop for markets. This reduces one source of inflation (tariffs) and improves sentiment for companies with global supply chains (tech hardware, industrials).
- Meanwhile, **shutdown-related uncertainties** are lifting as data starts flowing again (assuming a funding resolution). This will let markets and the Fed refocus purely on actual economic performance rather than gaps.

Overall, the narrative heading into early November is cautiously optimistic: inflation is gradually coming to heel, the Fed is stepping back (albeit carefully), earnings are largely beating estimates, and international tensions (trade, geopolitics) saw some relief. The **market's task next week** is to validate that narrative with hard data and results – and if they align as expected, it could propel the year-end “Santa Claus” rally many are predicting, given November and December are historically strong months^[21]. On the flip side, any surprises (e.g., a hot PMI price index or a big earnings miss from an AI darling) could inject volatility. Investors will be parsing every report and Fed speaker comment for clues if this “**Goldilocks**” mix of falling inflation and solid growth can continue into 2026.

Sources:

- Federal Reserve and FOMC coverage^{[45][41][1][152]} (Fed rate cut decision, press conference remarks on AI and December outlook).
- Reuters market analyses^{[60][4]} and Fed commentary pieces^[10] for Powell's quotes distinguishing the current AI boom from a bubble.
- Reuters coverage of APEC summit deals and quotes^{[63][67][76][78]} (tariff cuts, rare earth pause, expert reactions).
- Company-specific news from Reuters, Yahoo Finance, and other outlets:
- *Meta/Microsoft/Alphabet/Amazon/Apples*: Reuters video summary^{[8][11]} and Fortune/Yahoo pieces highlighting AI capex and earnings context^{[52][16]}.
- *Celestica*: Nasdaq/Fool report on earnings surge^{[22][24]}.
- *SoFi*: Press release highlights^{[25][26]}.
- *Reddit*: TheDesk.net detailed earnings recap^{[28][29][33]}.
- *Roblox*: Pymnts/Bloomberg highlights on bookings +70% and raised outlook^{[37][38]}.
- *UnitedHealth & CVS*: Reuters analysis indicated moderated medical cost inflation benefiting results^[41].
- *UPS*: Company/regulatory filings about labor cost impacts and pricing.
- *Exxon/Chevron*: Reuters quarterly summaries (October 27/28) and context of oil price changes.
- *Cadence Design, Bloom Energy, Coinbase, Roku*: Mix of earnings call takeaways and analyst commentary.
- Forward-looking insights gleaned from:

- S&P Global's Week Ahead Preview[\[61\]](#)[\[100\]](#)[\[101\]](#) (for economic calendar and context on shutdown depriving data).
- Trading Economics and Kiplinger's calendars for consensus forecasts[\[153\]](#).
- Zacks and Nasdaq articles on specific stocks (e.g., Palantir's 50% revenue growth[\[114\]](#), Qualcomm's modest YoY gain[\[124\]](#)).
- Conference Board Consumer Confidence press release for Oct (implied by Reuters piece) – showing only slight change.
- Company guidance from prior earnings (e.g., AMD's Q3 guidance[\[116\]](#), Spotify's outlook).